

DE LA LETTRE À L'ESPRIT

FROM THE LETTER TO THE SPIRIT



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DE LA LETTRE À L'ESPRIT

TRAVAUX EN HOMMAGE
À MOHAMMAD ALI AMIR-MOEZZI

FROM THE LETTER TO THE SPIRIT

STUDIES IN HONOUR
OF MOHAMMAD ALI AMIR-MOEZZI

Volume II

Sous la direction éditoriale de
Orkhan MIR-KASIMOV & Mathieu TERRIER



Collection

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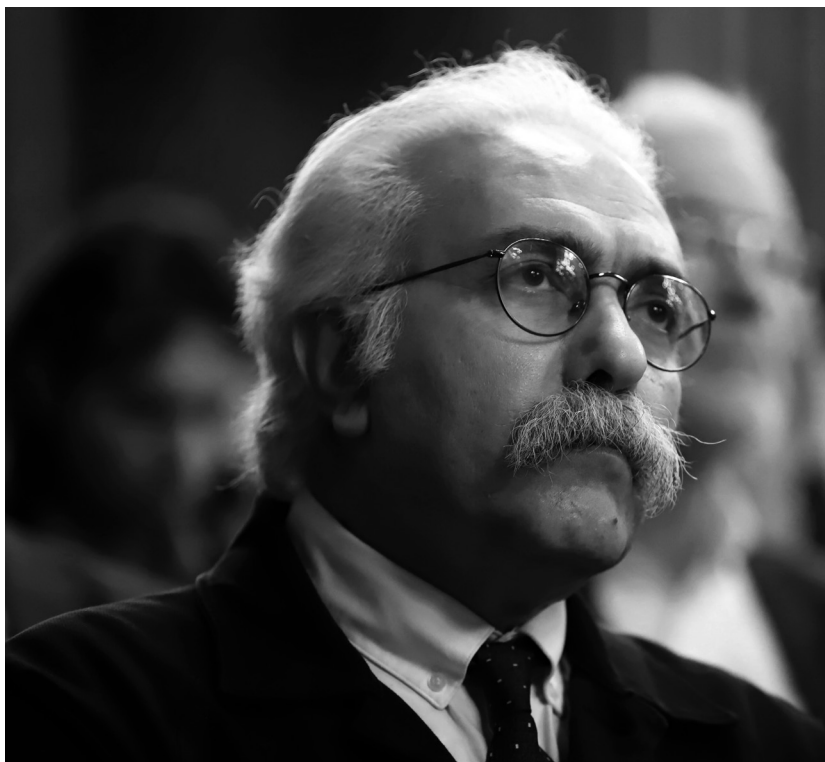
Série Études persanes

Fondé en 2000 aux États-Unis et dirigé par M^{me} Elahé Omidyar-Mir Djalali, le *Roshan Cultural Heritage Institute* soutient la préservation, la transmission et la diffusion académique et culturelle de la langue et de la culture iraniennes dans toute leur diversité. Il est à l'origine de la création des dizaines de chaires et de centre d'études persanes dans les universités d'Amérique du Nord (UCLA, Arizona, North Carolina/Chapel Hill, Washington, Maryland, Toronto...).

De la Perse antique à l'Iran islamique, la recherche sur cette civilisation millénaire a toujours été présente à l'EPHE, depuis ses débuts jusqu'à nos jours. C'est la raison pour laquelle l'EPHE-PSL était le lieu académique tout indiqué pour la création en 2023 du Centre *Elahé Omidyar Mir Djalali d'études persanes* grâce au *Roshan Cultural Heritage Institute*. L'EPHE-PSL est la première institution scientifique européenne qui bénéficie de ce soutien. Mohammad Ali Amir-Moezzi en est le premier directeur.

Le *Roshan Cultural Heritage Institute* servira de centre international d'excellence pour la recherche, la formation, la diffusion des connaissances sur tous les aspects de la civilisation et de la culture iraniennes. Ses activités s'adresseront aux chercheurs et étudiants de l'École, aux établissements membres de PSL et aux autres universités y compris étrangères, ainsi qu'à la communauté intellectuelle de l'aire culturelle iranisée. La série « Études persanes », au sein de la collection BEHE-SR, et les ouvrages qu'elle accueille font partie de ces activités.





MĪR DĀMĀD'S ON DOFFING: SAFAVID PHILOSOPHY, RITUAL MAGIC AND OUT-OF-BODY EXPERIENCE

Matthew MELVIN-KOUSHKI

University of South Carolina

*One cannot be counted a philosopher as long as he has
not acquired the ability to doff his body and ascend.¹*

Suhravardī

The only way out is in.²

Timothy Leary

TO ASCEND IS TO KNOW: this is the animating ethos of Neoplatonic philosophy-as-practice. Likely inspired by the Babylonian embrace of astronomy-astrology and astral magic, such a weirdly upward-straining definition of philosophy departed diametrically from ancient West Afro-Eurasian precedent, including Egyptian, Greek and Hebrew, committed rather to this-world and underworld journeying, to Endarkenment as Enlightenment.³ Its late antique epitome was Hermetic spirituality on the one hand and Gnostic on the other, both of which centrally focused

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1. *Al-Talwihāt al-lawḥiyya wa-l-ʿarshiyya*, ed. Najaf-qulī Ḥabībī (Tehran, 1388 Sh./2009), p. 281.
 2. R. Greenfield, *Timothy Leary: A Biography* (Orlando, FL, 2006), p. 281.
 3. The literature is vast: E. Fontainelle, *Secret History of Western Esotericism Podcast*, episodes 33, 113, 131; J. Finamore, *Iamblichus and the Theory of the Vehicle of the Soul* (Chico, CA, 1985); S. I. Johnston, "Rising to the Occasion: Theurgic Ascent in Its Cultural Milieu", in P. Schäfer, H. G. Kippenberg, ed., *Envisioning Magic: A Princeton Seminar and Symposium* (Leiden, 1997), pp. 165–194; P. Hadot, *Philosophy as a Way of Life*, tr. M. Chase (Oxford, 1995). In Plato's own works, references to out-of-body experience occur in the *Republic*, *Phaedo*, *Phaedrus* and *Theaetetus*.

on specific mind-altering practices, even technologies, for experientially quitting one's physical body for the supernal realms of light, the sole means of achieving direct, ultimately ineffable knowledge (*gnōsis*) of reality. Likewise in the later Hebrew merkavah (chariot) tradition that helped birth kabbalah, to ascend, to know, is to heal the soul.⁴ Through myriad repackagings since, the will to ascent has persisted at the heart of Western (Judeo-Christo-Islamic) cosmology for the last two millennia, and shows no signs of abating. Indeed, the transhumanist and transplanetary colonialist movements currently in vogue – curiously Gnostic too! – may be read as materialist, sci-fi, tech-bro riffs on this enduring theme, and the American evangelical invention of Rapture an equally militarised version of the same.

Peculiarly Hermetic, however, is the maxim *to ascend and know is to heal the soul – and the body*. Paradoxically embracing both Platonic idealism and Aristotelian materialism, this double-barrel procedure, epitomised by Iamblichean theurgy, renders the sage a talisman marrying heaven to earth not to negate or escape the latter but to bring beautiful balance to both.⁵

The same therapeutic ascent-and-descent ethos defined Islamic philosophy too since its inception, profoundly Neoplatonic to a greater degree than its Latin Christian cognates. In terms of sheer textual productivity over the last millennium, indeed, it must be counted the core of the “Western tradition”: the hallowed names Plato, Pythagoras and Plotinus (as Aristotle) were invoked far more often in Arabic, Persian and other Islamicate languages than in any Latinate one.⁶

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4. See e.g. W. J. Hanegraaff, *Hermetic Spirituality and the Historical Imagination: Altered States of Knowledge in Late Antiquity* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2022); D. M. Burns, *Apocalypse of the Alien God: Platonism and the Exile of Sethian Gnosticism* (Philadelphia, 2014); G. W. Trompf, G. B. Mikkelsen, J. Johnston, ed., *The Gnostic World* (Abingdon, 2019); J. R. Davila, *Descenders to the Chariot: The People behind the Hekhalot Literature* (Leiden, 2001); Naomi Janowitz, *The Poetics of Ascent: Theories of Language in a Rabbinic Ascent Text* (Albany, NY, 1989); M. Himmelfarb, *Ascent to Heaven in Jewish and Christian Apocalypses* (Oxford, 1993).
 5. W. J. Hanegraaff, *Hermetic Spirituality*, chapters 4, 6; G. Shaw, *Hellenic Tantra: The Theurgic Platonism of Iamblichus* (Brooklyn, NY, 2024).
 6. For intellectual-historical purposes, “the West” is best defined as that half of early modern Afro-Eurasia, encompassing over half of the human race, where Hellenic-Abrahamic dialectics came to reign supreme; see M. Melvin-Koushki, “*Tahqiq* vs. *Taqlid* in the Renaissance of Western Early Modernity”, *Philological Encounters* 3/1 (2018), pp. 193–249.

Likewise in contrast to its Latin Christian cognates, Islamic *gnōsis* tended and still tends to be much more Hermetic than Gnostic in its working out of the Prophetic project: to heal mind and body in tandem through ritual practice, to live well in both worlds, to ascend and descend to ascend again.⁷ Thus do the Quran and Hadith assert ascent to be the primary mode of prophecy, with Muḥammad's own flight (*mi'rāj*) to the ceiling of being and return with Revelation as ultimate exemplar; thus do a majority of Muslim sages – including in the first place Ibn Sīnā (d. 1037, Avicenna), the second Aristotle – assert it to be the primary mode of philosophy in equal measure: prophets and philosophers meet on the Moon. The anonymous tenth-century network of Pythagorean, occultist encyclopedists famed as the Brethren of Purity (*Ikhwān al-Ṣafā'*) are even more explicit, announcing *'ilm al-tajrīd* – the science of stripping off one's body – to be the culmination of philosophic education, together with alchemy, medicine, astrology and talismanic magic. Balancing such worldly technologies, it is only by means of this science of stripping that “the soul comes to know its essence, and through its divestment is made to behold its enduring stronghold”.⁸ Drawing from the same Pythagorean well, the gnostic philosophy of Ibn 'Arabī (d. 1240) and the multitude of his heirs (including the self-styled New Brethren of Purity) likewise pivots on the theme of ascent as human perfection, propounding the astonishing notion that saint, regardless of ethnic, religious or cultural background, can outstrip prophet in the exploration and control of the cosmos – especially linguistically and mathematically. At the same time, the greatest Western prophets are fused with the planetary intelligences and may be invoked as their avatars.⁹ The Illuminationist philosophy of Suhrawardī (d. 1191) – a more thoroughlygoing Neoplatonic riff on the Avicennan

7. That the Christian doctrine of the Fall of Man is categorically rejected by the Quran made dualistic re-readings of world-affirming Hermetic monism much less common among Muslim thinkers historically. By contrast, many modern scholars, reflexively following Christian precedent, have back-projected world-rejecting dualism onto the surviving Hermetica. Gross misreadings of the *Poimandres* (CH I) are a case in point; see W. J. Hanegraaff, *Hermetic Spirituality*, pp. 170–176.

8. *Ikhwān al-Ṣafā'*, *Rasā'il*, 4 vols. (Beirut, 2005), 4:236.

9. See e.g. T. Burckhardt, *Mystical Astrology According to Ibn 'Arabi*, trans. Bulent Rauf (Lexington, 2001).

system – similarly marries philosophy to astral magic, as does Ibn Sīnā's competitor Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī (d. 1210): both lay out comprehensive rituals of planetary ascent as the heart of Islamic philosophic praxis.¹⁰

In tribute to Professor Amir-Moezzi, whose sweeping oeuvre to date continues to profoundly shape the study of Shi'i thought and practice, I revisit that most eminent of Illuminationist philosophers and Twelver divines of high Safavid Iran, Sayyid Muḥammad Bāqir Ḥusaynī Astarābādī, aka Mīr Dāmād (d. 1631): the Third Master's famous account of one of his own ascent experiences is among the most mesmerizingly beautiful, philosophically precise and theurgically actionable in the early modern Western record.¹¹ Simply but significantly titled *On Doffing* (*R. al-Khal'iyya*), this brief Arabic treatise was first brought to Islamicists' attention by Henry Corbin (d. 1978), who held it up as proof for his guiding argument for Shi'ism, essentially and timelessly mystical, as the spiritual core of Islam and Iranianness in tandem.¹² He rightly paired it with another of Mīr Dāmād's visionary accounts, wherein the Safavid sage received an amuletic incantation (*hīrz*) directly from Muḥammad and 'Alī during a post-prayer hypnagogic accession. True to Corbin's phenomenological, religionist, anti-modernist approach, however, both accounts serve only as instances of Safavid Twelver "mysticism" and "esotericism", unsusceptible of rational or historical explanation – and certainly having nothing to do with the natural science that is "magic".

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10. J. Walbridge, "The Devotional and Occult Works of Suhrawardī the Illuminationist", *Iṣrāq* 2 (2011), pp. 80–97; Ł. Piątak, *Between Philosophy, Mysticism and Magic: A Critical Edition of Occult Writings of and Attributed to Shihāb al-Dīn al-Suhrawardī (1156–1191)* (PhD dissertation, University of Warsaw, 2018); M.-S. Noble, *Philosophising the Occult: Avicennan Psychology and "The Hidden Secret" of Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī* (Berlin, 2021). On the philhellenic and perennialist ethos of Illuminationism more generally see J. Walbridge, *The Wisdom of the Mystic East: Suhrawardī and Platonic Orientalism* (Albany, NY, 2001); J. Walbridge, *The Leaven of the Ancients: Suhrawardī and the Heritage of the Greeks* (Albany, NY, 2000). On possible historical and textual transmissions of Hermetic teachings as inspiration for Illuminationist philosophic practice see K. van Bladel, *The Arabic Hermes: From Pagan Saint to Prophet of Science* (Oxford, 2009); W. J. Hanegraaff, *Hermetic Spirituality*, pp. 332–341.
 11. M. A. Amir-Moezzi, *The Spirituality of Shi'i Islam* [3], p. 347. On his biography and thought see Sayyid 'Alī Mudarris Mūsavī Bihbahānī, *Ḥakīm-i Astarābād: Mīr Dāmād* (Tehran, 1370 Sh./1991); J. Jahānbakhsh, *Mu'allim-i sālis: zindagīnāma-yi Mīr Dāmād* (Tehran, 1389 Sh./2010).
 12. H. Corbin, *En Islam iranien. Aspects spirituels et philosophiques*, 4 vols. (Paris, 1972), vol. IV, chap. 1: "Confessions extatiques de Mīr Dāmād".

I contend, to the contrary, that both accounts are neither exclusively nonrational nor esoteric according to our philosopher's own Illuminist and lettrist epistemology, and are in fact quite explicitly *magical*. To this end, I translate them here into English for the first time to open them to wider comparative study, and as corrective to Corbin's French translations, unusably tendentious and sloppy. I likewise provide the basic necessary historical and conceptual framing to enable the modern historian to read these accounts *as they were intended to be and have long been read*.¹³ As such, the present offering serves as an appendix to Mathieu Terrier's recent, masterful study of Mīr Dāmād as preeminent legal and spiritual authority, emphasizing the inextricability of esoteric from exoteric knowledge and imperial power, which includes much more accurate French translations of the same.¹⁴

But I take this argument further to propose a new category in the study of Shi'ism, complementing Professor Amir-Moezzi's "esoteric nonrationalism":¹⁵ Mīr Dāmād's Neoplatonic philosophy-as-practice also exemplifies *occult rationalism*, a theurgic way of knowing, being and doing common to Shi'i and Sunni, Muslim and Christian and Jew, throughout the early modern West. As mainstream practice among elites and commoners alike, the lettrist operations it depends on can hardly be sociologically described as esoteric, for all that their mechanism is technically occult (*khafī*), or better, weird (*gharīb*). By the same token, Mīr Dāmād, among the leading Safavid proponents of lettrism (*ilm al-ḥurūf*) as an ideal means of doing and living philosophy, categorically asserts its empirical and experimentally verified (*tajribī*) nature.¹⁶

13. I follow here Hanegraaff's approach in *Hermetic Spirituality*.

14. M. Terrier, "Mīr Dāmād (m. 1041/1631), philosophe et mujtahid: Autorité spirituelle et autorité juridique en Iran safavide shī'ite", *Studia Islamica* 113/2 (2018), pp. 121–165, esp. p. 152–154, 156–157.

15. See especially his *The Divine Guide* [1] and *The Spirituality of Shi'i Islam* [3], *passim*.

16. M. Melvin-Koushki, "World as (Arabic) Text: Mīr Dāmād and the Neopythagoreanization of Philosophy in Safavid Iran", *Studia Islamica* 114/3 (2019), pp. 378–431; T. Zadeh, *Wonders and Rarities: The Marvelous Book That Traveled the World and Mapped the Cosmos* (Cambridge, MA, 2023). For the most recent research on this science, see the entries by E. Sartell, C. Uy, F. De Block, A. Viengkhou, Z. Winters, D. Rašić and S. Emre at IOSOTR (islamicoccult.org). This is not, it must be emphasised, the lettrism of the titular Ḥurūfiyya and their Nuqtaviyya offshoot. Denounced by mainstream lettrists like Ibn Turka and 'Abd al-Raḥmān al-Bisṭāmī, their messianic anti-Arabic anarchism represented a persistent sociopolitical problem from the early Timurid period to

Here the modern academic discipline of parapsychology (aka psychophysics) may serve as antidote to the currently standard disciplinary allergy toward such claims as smacking of medieval Moslem superstition, not merely nonrational but inherently *irrational*. Weirdly enough, the Neoplatonic, occultist accounts of our Safavid sage tally well with the large body of empirical parapsychological data over the last century, particularly with respect to the out-of-body experience (OBE): simply put, even modern Western humans, regardless of religious or cultural outlook, tend to ascend too, sometimes acquiring knowledge that is experimentally falsifiable – and hence *rational* by even the most parsimonious definition. It is this experiential, human reality that prompted the classification of occult science under the rubric of natural and mathematical science in all the major Arabic and Persian encyclopedias of the sciences down to and through the colonial era, where Hellenic, Hermetic intellect (*‘aql*) – here often meaning *nous* – runs the gamut from logic to talismanry, from astronomy to body-doffing, and at least half of the rational sciences are explicitly occult.¹⁷

Our own categorizations aside, then, Mīr Dāmād saw himself as practising his Illuminationist philosophy in modes simultaneously gnostic (*‘irfānī*) and scientific (*‘aqlī*), suprarational and rational, both equally empirical – hence his marriage of Platonic metaphysics to Aristotelian physics by means of lettrist magic, which prophetic-imamic-philosophic practice he embraced as an especially effective technology of ascent.

the high Safavid, when Shah ‘Abbās I, after dallying with Nuṭṭāvisim as a means of reinforcing his sacral kingship, brutally persecuted and exiled the movement, which found much more success at the Mughal court. On the original Ḥurūfī doctrine see O. Mir-Kasimov, *Words of Power. Ḥurūfī Teachings between Shi‘ism and Sufism in Medieval Islam: The Original Doctrine of Faḍl Allāh Astarābādī* (London, 2015); on the Nuṭṭāvī controversy during Mīr Dāmād’s lifetime see K. Babayan, *Mystics, Monarchs, and Messiahs: Cultural Landscapes of Early Modern Iran* (Cambridge, MA, 2002).

17. M. Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One: The Mathematicalization of the Occult Sciences in the High Persianate Tradition”, *Intellectual History of the Islamic World* 5/1 (2017), pp. 127–199; M. Melvin-Koushki, “Is (Islamic) Occult Science Science?” *Theology and Science* 18/2 (2020), pp. 303–324. Especially illuminating here are Professor Amir-Moezzi’s discussions on the frequent ambiguity of the Arabic term *‘aql* as a term of contention, including in the early Shi‘i context, variously translatable as “hiero-intelligence” and “dialectical reasoning”. For Mīr Dāmād and his fellow Illuminationists, however, these apparently conflicting senses of the term are easily reconcilable by means of philosophically and empirically rigorous gnosis.

Mīr Dāmād the Philosopher

Despite his status as the preeminent Illuminationist philosopher of the turn of the seventeenth century, Mīr Dāmād's oeuvre has remained far less studied than that of his now much more famous student Mullā Ṣadrā Shīrāzī (d. 1636), due not least to its frequently ornate and abstruse style. What is clear, however, is that his life's project was the creation of a new philosophy of time, centered on the concept of *ḥudūth dahrī*, metatemporal becoming, whereby eternal, timefree being perpetually becomes time-bound.¹⁸ I have observed elsewhere that this concept may be profitably read in lettrist terms too at the author's own insistence: his *Lamp of Illumination and Keeping the Balance* (*Nibrās al-ḍiyā' wa-taswā' al-sawā'*) explicitly marries it to that Pythagorean-^cAlid science to explain the mechanics of effective prayer – which is to say, magic. The unprecedented, passionately Shi'ī philosophy of history he propounds also makes history a *science*.¹⁹

Likewise central to all Mīr Dāmād's thought is the pseudepigraphal *Theology of Aristotle* (*Uthūlūjīyā*). Renewed interest in that medieval Arabic epitome of Plotinian Neoplatonism is of course a hallmark of Safavid philosophy generally, which thus serves as emblem of its philhellenizing and perennialist-antiquarianist tenor.²⁰ But our Safavid sage goes farther than his peers in declaring the entirety of his large oeuvre to simply be an explication of the *Theology* – which has body-doffing as a central theme. That he

18. M. Terrier, "Mīr Dāmād"; S. Rizvi, "Mīr Dāmād's (d. 1631) *al-Qabasāt*: The Problem of the Eternity of the Cosmos", in K. El-Rouayheb, S. Schmidtke, ed., *The Oxford Handbook of Islamic Philosophy* (Oxford, 2017), pp. 438–464.

19. M. Terrier, "The Wisdom of God and the Tragedy of History: The Concept of Appearance (*badā'*) in Mīr Dāmād's *Lantern of Brightness*", in S. N. Ahmad, S. Rizvi, ed., *Philosophy and the Intellectual Life in Shī'ah Islam* (London, 2017), pp. 94–133; M. Melvin-Koushki, "World as (Arabic) Text", pp. 393–394, 419–420; cf. M. Melvin-Koushki, "Shaykhi Prayer as Safavid-Qajar Occult Technology", English introduction to Muṣṭafā b. Muḥammad Hādī Khū'ī (d. 1839), *Hidden Gems and Treasured Pearls* (*Javāhir-i makhnūna u la'ālī-yi makhzūna*), ed. Alireza Asghari and Muhammad Abdullahiyan (Leiden, 2022), pp. 5–31. That Mīr Dāmād conceived of ritual prayer as a body-doffing practice is confirmed in his categorisation of his ritually programmatic *Source Questions* (*Uyūn al-masā'il*) as a specifically khalīfī work; see M. Mūsavī, *Ḥakīm-i Astarābād*, p. 140.

20. S. Rizvi, "(Neo)Platonism Revived in the Light of the Imams: Qāḍī Sa'īd Qummi (d. AH 1107/AD 1696) and His Reception of the *Theologia Aristotelis*", in P. Adamson, ed., *Classical Arabic Philosophy: Sources and Reception* (London, Turin, 2007), pp. 176–207; R. Pourjavady, S. Schmidtke, "An Eastern Renaissance? Greek Philosophy under the Safavids (16th–18th Centuries ad)", *Intellectual History of the Islamicate World* 3 (2015), pp. 248–290; P. Adamson, *The Arabic Plotinus: A Philosophical Study of the Theology of*

makes this declaration in his *Firebrands and Epiphanies* (*Jazavāt u mavāqīt*), a comparatively accessible Persian summary of his philosophical system wholly recast in lettrist terms, is likewise telling in this occult context.²¹

Mīr Dāmād, in short, holds up the *Uthūlūjīyā* as ultimate ancient Hellenic handbook of philosophic, gnostic ascent whose modern Irano-Islamic apotheosis is Illumination (*ishrāq*), Oriental Enlightenment, wherein body-doffing remains *de rigueur*. In this he follows faithfully the instructions of his school's founder almost five centuries prior; two instances from the master himself will here suffice.

In his magnum opus, *The Philosophy of Illumination* (*Ḥikmat al-ishrāq*), Suhrawardī leaves no doubt as to the necessarily traumatic nature of this path, featuring physical and imaginal attacks, seizures and trances productive of astonishment. Significantly for our occult theme, he specifies *talismans* as engines of ascent:

The brethren of incorporeality [*ikhwān al-tajrīd*]²² have a special station in which they are able to bring into existence self-subsistent images in whatever form they desire. This is called “the station of ‘Be.’” Whoever sees that station knows with certainty the existence of a world other than that of barriers. In it are self-subsistent images and managing angels, taking for themselves talismans and self-subsistent forms by which they speak and are evident. From there flow violent attacks and overwhelming seizures by astonishing images and sounds of which the imagination can in no wise tell. How very strange that a man hears that sound in a certain incorporeality and attends to it, finding at that moment that his imagination also listens to it, though that sound is from a suspended image! Whoever has experienced this in his divine trances as he ascends will not return until he has ascended from level to level of the agreeable forms. The more perfect his ascent, the purer and more delightful will be his contemplation of forms. Thereafter, he will penetrate to the world of light and finally reach the Light of Lights.²³

Aristotle (London, 2002). By sharp and ironic contrast, modern academic philhellenism is rather the hallmark of “internal Eurocentrism”; see W. J. Hanegraaff, *Hermetic Spirituality*, pp. 16–18, 133–135, 360–362.

21. M. Melvin-Koushki, “World as (Arabic) Text”, p. 396.

22. I.e., discorporeality.

23. Shihāb al-Dīn Suhrawardī, *The Philosophy of Illumination* (*Ḥikmat al-ishrāq*), ed. and trans. J. Walbridge, H. Ziai (Provo, UT, 1999), p. 155.

Likewise, in his seminal *Intimations from the Tablet and the Throne* (*al-Tal-wihāt al-lawḥiyya wa-l-ʿarshiyya*), Suhrawardī describes a visionary encounter with Aristotle (or rather Plotinus) in which they discussed the nature of knowledge, using the same terminology of altered states of consciousness through ritually induced trauma:

During a period when I was intensely occupied with reflection and devotional exercise, having found the question of knowledge (*ʿilm*) to be a difficult one and the disquisitions in books to be of no help to me, one night there befell me a sleeplike seizure (*khulsa*) – I was suddenly overwhelmed by pleasure and struck by lightning and bathed in scintillating light! It contained the likeness of a man, which I peered at [more closely], and lo, it was the Guide of Souls, the Chief of Philosophers, the First Teacher himself, in such a splendid form as to amaze and astonish me! But he greeted me so warmly as to replace my astonishment and disorientation with intimacy. Thereupon I complained to him as to my difficulty with this question [...] ²⁴

This account continues at some length; Aristotle's dazzling shade concludes by exalting Plato above all other philosophers, while acknowledging that certain Sufis have attained a similar rank through ascetic and occult practice. Suhrawardī then cites the *Theology* as clinching proof for the specifically Hermetic nature of true, out-of-body philosophy:

Thus reported the First Teacher as to his personal experience of these great lights. All [philosophers] agree on the fact that whoever is able to doff (*khalʿ*) his body and reject his senses ascends (*ṣuʿūd*) to the supernal realm. They likewise agree on the fact that Hermes ascended to the supernal realm, as did other masters of the celestial ascent (*miʿrāj*). One cannot be counted a philosopher (*ḥakīm*) as long as he has not acquired the ability to doff his body and ascend (*taraqqī*). Heed not those materialist pseudo-philosophers knocking about blindly [here below]: the matter is far greater than what they assert. [As for true philosophers], some of their methods are occult (*khafī*), due to sheer nobility and grandeur, and others more manifest (*ẓāhir*). ²⁵



24. Suhrawardī, *al-Talwihāt*, pp. 238–243. This and all subsequent translations are mine.
25. Suhrawardī, *al-Talwihāt*, pp. 280–281. Cf. W. J. Hanegraaff, *Hermetic Spirituality*, pp. 335–341. Shaykh Bahāʾī quotes the same *Uthulūjiyā* episode via the *Talwihāt* with minor

For Mīr Dāmād too, the paradox – the *coincidentia oppositorum* – that is the marriage of temporal body to perpetual soul is the very basis of philosophy, whose definitive ancient expression is the *Theologia Aristotelis*. He cites it constantly in his magnum opus, *Blazing Brands* (*K. al-Qabasāt*), in particular, and references often grace the rest of his oeuvre. A case in point is *The Straight Path* (*al-Ṣirāṭ al-mustaqīm*), on his signature philosophy of meta-time, which quotes in full Plotinus’s famous passage on body-doffing (from *Ennead* IV.8.1) by way of introduction:

Aristotle testified in his *Theology* – that is, “knowledge of Lordly divinity” – as follows: “It was if I had secluded myself and doffed my body and left it behind, had transformed into something like a pure bodiless substance; I was wholly immersed in and rejoined with my essence and exited from all things. Thereupon I beheld in my essence such beauty and brilliance as to leave me permanently amazed and stupefied! I knew myself to be a part of the glorious and noble realm [supernal], and possessed of active life.

Having ascertained this [reality], I ascended in my mind (*dhihn*) from that realm to [that of] the divine [First] Cause, and it was if I were embedded within it and attached to it, above the noetic realm entire. I saw myself standing at that noble divine station, and saw therein such light and brilliance as speech cannot possibly express nor hearing comprehend – when lo: that light and brilliance overwhelmed me past all bearing! So I descended from the [realm] noetic back to that of reflective thought – yet having descended my reflection was still shattered by the same light and brilliance, and I remained incapacitated with astonishment as to how I could have possibly decamped from that exalted, divine place to the [nether] level of reflection, even after empowering my soul to escape its body and return to its essence and ascend to the realm noetic and then the realm divine, finally arriving at that place of sheer light and brilliance and universal cause of the same? Equally astonishing was how I could have possibly seen my soul suffused with light even while in the body according to its [gross] form and not external thereto?”²⁶

variations in his *Kashkūl* (3 vols. [Beirut, 1403/1983], 2:208), emphasising, significantly, its wondrous and weird (*‘ajīb u gharīb*) – that is, occult – nature. On the weird as simply good occult natural philosophy see T. Zadeh, *Wonders and Rarities*.

26. *Al-Ṣirāṭ al-mustaqīm*, ed. ‘Alī Awjabī (Tehran, 1381 Sh./2002), pp. 9–10; cf. *Uthūlūjīyā*, ed. ‘Abd al-Raḥmān Badawī, *Aflātūn ‘ind al-‘Arab* (Cairo, 1955), p. 22.

And in his *Droplets from Heaven* (*al-Rawāshih al-samāwiyya*), a work on hadith, Mīr Dāmād provides a succinct theological-psychological typology of this process, riffing on the central statement (and this article's epigraph) in the first *Intimations* passage above:

As for the degree of [true] philosophy (*ḥikma*) and gnosis (*ʿirfān*), it comprises a vast range. Its highest levels are the highest degrees of prophecy itself, its median ones legateship and caliphhood. Its lowest [and most common] ones pertain to those souls not strong enough in their substance to be capable of perceiving the nonvisible (*ghayb*) and the visible (*shahāda*) realms simultaneously, yet by virtue of extreme holiness, purity and burnished brilliance are nevertheless able to reject the body and take off (*naḍw*) the corporeal robe and undo the knots of the net that is nature, and repair to the realm of holiness and splendor and arrive at the illuminating noetic substances and behold the forms of knowledge they contain, seeking enlightenment through their dawning lights. For one cannot be counted a philosopher as long as he has not acquired the ability to doff his body, such that his body becomes to him a mere shirt that is worn sometimes and doffed at others.²⁷

Another of his star students, Quṭb al-Dīn Ishkavarī (d. btw. 1677–1684), philosopher-mathematician and Chief Jurisconsult of Lahijan, testifies to the continued centrality of this Illuminationist doctrine to the School of Isfahan. In *Hearts' Beloved* (*Maḥbūb al-qulūb*), a seminal antiquarianist, perennialist, philhellenist intellectual history, Ishkavarī tellingly places his discussions of body-doffing-as-philosophy in his lengthy, adoring entries on Pythagoras and Socrates. The rays of the Pythagorean True Sun and Central Fire that is the *nous* (*ʿaql*), needless to say, can only be bathed in by doffing the body and ascending to the vantage of the Moon – short of which one must dwell in the perpetual and inauspicious eclipse that is the sublunar sensorium.²⁸ And to body-doff is to voluntarily die, which Socrates (standing in for Plato standing in for Plotinus) declares to be the main business of the philosopher: “Whoso kills himself physically finds his body a grave; whoso kills himself with intent finds physical death eternal life for his soul.” Ishkavarī responds:



27. *Al-Rawāshih al-samāwiyya*, ed. N. A. Jalīlī, G.-H. Qayṣarī (Qom, 1380 Sh./2001), p. 63.

28. *Maḥbūb al-qulūb fī aḥwāl al-ḥukamāʾ wa-aqwālihim*, ed. I. Dībājī, Ḥ. Ṣidqī, 2 vols. (Tehran, 1382 Sh./2003), 1, pp. 230–231.

I say: The ultimate truth as directly verified by gnostic verifiers is that the body, while a useful net for bagging sciences and hunting various forms of knowledge, is rendered by its night stupors and binding fits a shackle to the holy noetic substance. To become tangled in one's own net is a curse to the hunter. But felicity for the noetic soul, native to the psychical realm, is the doffing of the body and the rejection of the sensory realm so as to return to its true home. Thus to die with intent is to perfect one's everliving, everknowing substance, which process natural death only completes.

The Resurrection promised in the Quran and Hadith, he concludes, is no eschatological event, but rather the perpetual possibility of a body-doffing *Apocalypse Now*.²⁹

Mīr Dāmād the Mage

The two key Arabic terms in all these accounts are *khulsa* and *khalʿ*: the first signifies the shocking seizure or abduction that initiates the second, the body-doffing experience. True to Illuminationist-Neoplatonic form, Mīr Dāmād generalizes the *khulsa* as vehicle of philosophic practice even in works that do not explicitly feature visionary ascent, such as his *Seized by the Psychical Realm* (*Khulsat al-malakūt*), a longer, programmatic philosophical treatise.³⁰ As the above excerpts make clear, however, our Safavid sage, invoking Suhrawardī and Plotinus, conceived of and experienced this objective as *Hermetic talismanic trauma*.

These three key, interdependent qualities of early modern Islamic and Persianate philosophic life – Hermetic, talismanic, traumatic – remain insufficiently addressed in modern scholarship. Corbin himself rightly observed that Mīr Dāmād's project was not merely theoretical, while suggesting the seventeenth-century Cambridge Platonists (not known for their experimentalist occult endeavours) for comparative study.³¹ Yet his

29. *Maḥbūb al-qulūb*, 1, pp. 248–249. No Sufi, Ishkavarī via Socrates is here riffing on the classic Sufi dictum *die before you die*. It must be emphasized in this context that his entries on Adam and Pythagoras are in places openly letrist; see *Maḥbūb al-qulūb*, 1, pp. 135–157, 208–236; M. Melvin-Koushki, “World as (Arabic) Text”, pp. 164–172. On this remarkable work see M. Terrier, “Le *Maḥbūb al-qulūb* de Qutb al-Dīn Ashkevarī: une œuvre méconnue dans l’histoire de l’histoire de la sagesse en islam”, *Journal Asiatique* 298/2 (2010), pp. 345–387.

30. *Muṣannafāt-i Mīr Dāmād*, ed. ‘Abd Allāh Nūrānī, 2 vols. (Tehran, 1381 Sh./2002), 1:281–328.

31. H. Corbin, *En Islam iranien*, IV, p. 18.

confessedly impressionistic account of the School of Isfahan elides all three elements for their taint of “practical magic”, on which basis he paints the two visionary accounts below, from 1603 and 1614 respectively, as being in tone “toute différente”.³² Indeed, Corbin goes so far as to recast the revealed amuletic incantation (*hirz*) of the first account in purely Jungian terms, as well as mandalic – a classic Eranos move.³³ But “intégration psycho-spirituelle” was hardly Mīr Dāmād’s only objective; he famously used the same prayerful, theurgic procedures to repel the 1630 Ottoman attack on Hamadan too, among other occult feats.³⁴ Simply restoring both accounts to their original textual, epistemological, technological, political and indeed military context therefore reveals more continuity than rupture: Mīr Dāmād’s practice was and remained ritual-magical over his august career, the surest means of inducing such seizures and abilities.

Per the standard hagiographical process, his renown as a sage-mage only grew after his death, and has remained alive and well through the colonial period. A case in point are the popular occultist manuals of uncertain provenance that continue to circulate under his name in cheap bazaar editions and online. Generically titled *Mīr Dāmād the Great* (*Mīr Dāmād-i kabīr*), these democratizing pulp grimoires declare “Teach yourself the occult arts and sciences!”³⁵

32. H. Corbin, *En Islam iranien*, IV, p. 36.

33. H. Corbin, *En Islam iranien*, IV, p. 38: that is, it is not a specifically magical technology, but rather an “initiation surnaturelle à une forme de prière ayant par excellence le sens d’une intégration psycho-spirituelle.” For a non-Jungian approach that does justice to the explicitly occult tenor of the sources see T. Zadeh, “Postscript: Cutting Ariadne’s Thread, or How to Think Otherwise in the Maze”, in L. Saif et al., ed., *Islamicate Occult Sciences in Theory and Practice* (Leiden, 2021), pp. 607–650.

34. Rasūl Ja’fariyān, *Naqsh-i khāndān-i Karakī dar ta’sīs u tadāwum-i dawlat-i Ṣafavī* (Tehran, 1387 Sh./2008), pp. 409–410. The feats of Mīr Dāmād and his peers – Shaykh Bahā’ī’s being the most spectacular – are documented in the early seventeenth-century expansion, by Shah ‘Abbās’s court astrologer-historian Jalāl al-Dīn Munajjim Yazdī (d. 1619), of an important Timurid grimoire, Ḥusayn Vā‘iz Kāshifī’s (d. 1505) *Qasimian Secrets*; this best-selling who’s who of Safavid state occultism is an anthem to the principle that Islamic philosophy is best lived as magic. See M. Subtelny, “Kāshifī’s *Asrār-i qāsimī*: A Late Timurid Manual of the Occult Sciences and Its Safavid Afterlife”, in L. Saif et al., ed., *Islamicate Occult Sciences in Theory and Practice*, pp. 267–313.

35. M. Melvin-Koushki, “World as (Arabic) Text”, p. 421. This list of arts usually follows: the subjugation, invocation and summoning of jinn, people and angels; incantations for success and good fortune, for seeking children, love, money, provision, the sale of goods, conquest and victory; and the countering of talismans and sorcery.

For all his lettrist commitments, however, Mīr Dāmād's reputation in his own day as a dread mage paled in comparison with several of his closest colleagues. These include Shaykh Bahā'ī (d. 1621), ultimate Safavid Renaissance Man and Chief Jurisconsult, who was and is famed for his expertise in all sciences manifest and occult, especially the mathematical and magical ones, and redesigned the new Safavid capital, Isfahan, as a Pythagorean, Solomonic, talismanic paradise. Mīr Findiriskī (d. 1640), a fellow founder of the philosophical School of Isfahan, specialized rather in alchemy and yoga; he sojourned many years in India and became a Sanskrit-Persian translator to that end. Mīr Faṭḥ Allāh Shīrāzī (d. 1589) was likewise renowned as a renaissance man, with particular expertise in talismanry and military engineering (for him the two disciplines are occult and contiguous). He is credited with introducing Islamic philosophy to India at the instance of his student Muḥammad Dihdār Shīrāzī (d. 1607), a productive Akbarian thinker in his own right, and son of Maḥmūd Dihdār Shīrāzī (fl. 1576), the most prolific Persian author on lettrism of the sixteenth century – and teacher to Shaykh Bahā'ī himself in the occult sciences: his manuals constituted the state of the applied lettrist art during Mīr Dāmād's lifetime, and develop an unprecedented program of Twelver talismanry.

Despite this friendly competition, our Safavid philosopher still deserves credit for performing one of the most remarkable feats in all of Western intellectual history: he seems to have been singlehandedly responsible for transmogrifying Ibn Sīnā himself (no booster of the occult sciences) into a Pythagorean occultist – a feat, fittingly enough, on a par with the *Theology's* transmogrification of Plotinus into Aristotle!³⁶

36. M. Melvin-Koushki, "World as (Arabic) Text"; M. Melvin-Koushki, "Pseudo-Shaykh Bahā'ī on the Supreme Name, a Safavid-Qajar Lettrist Classic", in J. J. Elias, B. Orfali, ed., *Light upon Light: Essays in Islamic Thought and History in Honor of Gerhard Bowering* (Leiden, 2019), pp. 256–290; M. Melvin-Koushki, "Occult Ecumenism: Maḥmūd Dihdār Shīrāzī's *Unveiling Secrets* as Exemplar of Timurid-Safavid Sunni-Shi'i Science", *Iranian Studies* 55/5–6 (2022), pp. 1–31. On early modern Islamic occultism as a conscious continuation and expansion of Avicennan natural philosophy see D. Gutas, "Avicenna and After: The Development of Paraphilosophy. A History of Science Approach", in Abdelkader Al Ghouz, ed., *Islamic Philosophy from the 12th to the 14th Century* (Göttingen, 2018), pp. 19–71.



Plate 1. Cosmic 'ayn-nūn diagram, 50 × 72 cm, Farjam Foundation, London; photo courtesy of the Farjam Foundation, DIFC, Dubai, United Arab Emirates.³⁷

His writings and exploits aside, perhaps the most revealing window onto Mīr Dāmād's personal philosophic practice is a gorgeous, monumental, early seventeenth-century lettrist diagram preserved at the Farjam Foundation in London, now studied by Christiane Gruber. The largest-known specimen of Islamicate cosmological diagrams to date – and almost certainly, and unusually, meant to be hung for ritual purposes –, it provides a mesmerizing, wonder-inducing prop for visualizing the Prophetic Seal in the shape of ϵ as “a schematized ‘Alid image of cosmic

37. Ch. Gruber, “‘Ayn Seal”, p. 523.

in-betweenness.”³⁸ And this iconic piece of Safavid psychedelia has Mīr Dāmād’s prints all over it, quite literally, or rather *lettrarily*: the opening Arabic double couplet from his *Firebrands and Epiphanies* in the top right quadrant looms larger than all other texts, and is balanced in the top left by Sanā’ī’s (d. c. 1138) verses celebrating his poetic art as encompassing the cosmos.³⁹ If our philosopher did not commission or ritually gaze upon this signed cosmic diagram himself, his students and admirers certainly did, given the signs of frequent use – precisely as a means of doffing the body to experience meta-time.⁴⁰

Another, equally gorgeous window onto Mīr Dāmādic meta-time was made less than a half-century after his death. Muḥammad Zamān (fl. 1704), the celebrated Safavid book painter in service to Shah Sulaymān I (r. 1666–1694), was commissioned in 1675 to illustrate a royal copy of Firdawsī’s *Book of Kings* (*Shāhnāma*) as ultimate symbol of Islamo-Persian empire, as his predecessors had done so often before. His depiction of the episode of the presentation of Īraj’s head to Farīdūn is wonderfully empirical, and features his patron putting an Ottoman envoy in his place with this grisly gift. Compositionally, however, Muḥammad Zamān breaks rather shockingly from Persianate precedent: he quotes an architectural print by the Dutch artist Hendrik Hondius (d. 1650) to recast the scene in perspectivist terms – then, true to his name, transforms it into a meditation on Mīr Dāmād’s trinity of time-metatime-eternity. Here all action is simultaneous, and the vanishing point is not the terrestrial horizon, per West European custom,

38. Ch. Gruber, “The Prophet Muḥammad’s ‘Ayn Seal: A Safavid-Period Diagram as Cosmic Vision”, in J. Hamburger, D. Roxburgh, L. Safran, ed., *The Diagram as Paradigm: Cross-Cultural Approaches* (Cambridge, MA, 2022), pp. 515–531, esp. 532.

39. *Jazavāt u mavāqīt*, ed. ‘Alī Awjabī, gloss. Mullā ‘Alī Nūrī (Tehran, 1380 Sh./2001), 1. This lettrist *dūbayt* is translated in M. Melvin-Koushki, “World as (Arabic) Text”, p. 420, note 151:

Two ‘ayns, two ‘ayns not written by any pen,
each of the two ‘ayns having two ‘ayns within it.

Two nūns, two nūns not written by any pen,
each of the two nūns having two nūns within it.

The diagram not only plots both verses precisely, couching six nūns within six ‘ayns, but does so in strikingly lunar terms – an act of devotion to ‘Alī, the Moon to Muḥammad’s Sun, and hence spiritual and physical embodiment of his Seal.

40. On such ritual practice see the articles in G. M. Martini, ed., *Visualizing Sufism: Studies on Graphic Representations in Sufi Literature (13th to 16th Century)* (Leiden, 2023), in particular N. Gardiner, “Diagrams and Visionary Experience in al-Būnī’s *Laṭā’if al-ishārāt fi al-ḥurūf al-ulwīyāt*”.



Plate 2. Muḥammad Zamān, detached folio illustration for court *Shāhnāma* (1675) dedicated to Shah Sulaymān I (CBL Per 277.16, public domain).

but the second-story door above the small palatial arch at the end of the cypress-lined promenade, all symbols rich with Persianate poetic and philosophic significance. Needless to say, the Italian Renaissance invention of perspectivist painting – of explicitly Pythagorean inspiration – has long been touted by art historians as a proof of European epistemological and sensory superiority.⁴¹ But Muḥammad Zamān here shows himself to



41. On this inspiration see Ch. Joost-Gaugier, *Pythagoras and Renaissance Europe: Finding Heaven* (Cambridge, 2014).

be an even more thoroughgoing Pythagorean: his perspectivist painting of an infamous ancient beheading is designed instead to “behead” the viewer, and geometrically induce ascent.⁴²



Painting opens a window onto the world; architecture paints the page of the world itself. The early seventeenth-century revolutionary redesign of Isfahan as Safavid imperial capital by Shaykh Bahā'ī, Mīr Dāmād's imperial brother-in-arms, was equally Pythagorean and perspectivist – and hence equally talismanic – to an extent unparalleled by western European city-scapes for centuries. Beginning from the central “Image of the World” (*naqsh-i jahān*) palace-complex square, its denizens' procession down the new, Four-Paradise (*chahār bāgh*) boulevard offered a therapeutic and theurgic prospect to the horizon across the Living (*zāyanda*) River, terminating at the city's Necropolis of Saints. The construction of Solomon's Throne (*takht-i Sulaymān*) on Mount Portico (*ṣuffa*) immediately to the south likewise invited the day-trip viewer, both elite and common, to read the famously paradisiacal city as Solomonian text, as talisman, as engine of sacral power (*valāyat*).⁴³ That these consciously modernizing Safavid philosophers hailed

42. M. Carey, *Meeting in Isfahan: Vision and Exchange in Safavid Iran*, exhibition catalog (Dublin, 2022), p. 144, CBL Per 277.16; see A. Landau, “Man, Mode, and Myth: Muhammad Zaman ibn Haji Yusuf”, in A. S. Landau, ed., *Pearls on a String: Artists, Patrons, and Poets at the Great Islamic Courts* (Baltimore, 2015), pp. 167–203. My thanks to the participants in the associated *Seeing Isfahan: Perspectives on the Safavid Image* exhibition conference (Trinity College Dublin, 27–28 May 2022), organised by Moya Carey and Anna McSweeney, for the extraordinarily rich discussions informing my examples here. On the new theory in Safavid album prefaces of painting as a form of specifically lettrist magic see M. Melvin-Koushki, “Of Islamic Grammatology: Ibn Turka's Lettrist Metaphysics of Light”, *Al-ʿUṣūr al-Wuṣṭā* 24 (2016), pp. 46–117, esp. 84–88.

43. F. Emami, *Isfahan: Architecture and Urban Experience in Early Modern Iran* (University Park, PA, 2024), chap. 8 (my thanks to Prof. Emami for an advance look); on Isfahan's new sacral and secular urban fabric more specifically see his “Inviolable Thresholds, Blessed Palaces, and Holy Friday Mosques: The Sacred Topography of Safavid Isfahan”, in A. H. Ugurlu, S. Yalman, ed., *The Friday Mosque in the City: Liminality, Ritual, and Politics* (Bristol, 2020), pp. 159–195; and “Discursive Images and Urban Itineraries: Literary Form and City Experience in Early Modern Iran”, *Journal for Early Modern Cultural Studies* 18/3 (2018), pp. 154–186. It must be emphasised that this Safavid Pythagorean architectural ethos was developed in competition with its Mughal and Ottoman Persianate peers, and was competed with in turn; see G. Necipoğlu, “Transregional Connections: Architecture and the Construction of Early Modern Islamic Empires”, in

Solomon (with Hermes) as supreme ancient authority on occult science and teacher of Pythagoras and Plato suggests that they saw their new imperial capital as ultimate Platonopolis, whose built fabric was designed to simultaneously heal the body and transport the mind.

But its most explicitly Pythagorean and lettrist structure is the Shaykh Luṭf Allāh Mosque on the imperial square itself (see plate 3 on next page). Mesmerizing and astonishing in its interior design, interspersed throughout with verses by Shaykh Bahā'ī, its central vault depicts the Descent of the mathematical One through the linguistic Many and maps a quranic, theurgic means of Ascent again – which means are the divine Names themselves, broadcast to the world on the dome's exterior.⁴⁴

These are the textual, visual and architectural contexts in which Mīr Dāmād's two recorded visionary accounts must be read. Even stripped of their lived contexts, moreover, his accounts are too terminologically precise, *pace* Corbin, to admit of any doubt as to their shared ritual-magical nature.

The first, his experience of 1603, pivots on the term *ḥirz*, amulet or amuletic incantation. In contrast to a talisman (*ṭilasm*), by definition a

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- R. Ahluwalia, ed., *Reflections on Mughal Art & Culture* (New Delhi, 2021), pp. 255–285. On Mughal (Indo-Timurid) exemplars in particular – some even more explicitly occult – see E. Koch, *The Planetary King: Humayun Padshah, Inventor and Visionary on the Mughal Throne* (Ahmedabad, 2022); E. Koch, “The Taj Mahal: Architecture, Symbolism, and Urban Significance”, *Muqarnas* 22 (2005), pp. 128–149; E. Koch, “Carved Pools, Rock-Cut Elephants, Inscriptions, and Tree Columns: Mughal Landscape Art as Imperial Expression and Its Analogies to the Renaissance Garden”, in M. Gharipour, ed., *Gardens of Renaissance Europe and the Islamic Empires: Encounters and Influences* (University Park, PA, 2017), pp. 185–212. On comparisons with contemporary Italy – scene to a similarly occult Renaissance – see G. Necipoğlu, “Architectural Dialogues across the Eastern Mediterranean: Monumental Domed Sanctuaries in the Ottoman Empire and Renaissance Italy”, in A. Payne, ed., *The Companion to the History of Architecture*, vol. I, *Renaissance and Baroque Architecture* (Hoboken, NJ, 2017), pp. 594–623; M. Gharipour, “The Gardens of Safavid Isfahan and Renaissance Italy: A New Urban Landscape?”, in M. Gharipour, ed., *Gardens of Renaissance Europe and the Islamic Empires*, pp. 101–134.
44. F. Emami, “Inviolable Thresholds”. In its blatantly Neoplatonically theurgical design scheme, the Shaykh Luṭf Allāh Mosque, while (like the Tāj Maḥall) an apotheosis of the specifically Timurid style, is perhaps most reminiscent not of contemporary imperial edifices but of that most wondrous of Byzantine churches, the sixth-century Hagia Sophia: expressly, aniconically designed to embody and encourage the ascent procedure laid out in Plato's *Timaeus* both visually and aurally, it became model in turn for Ottoman mosque architecture. See P. M. Adams, *Hagia Sophia / Sanctum of Kronos: Spiritual Dissent in an Age of Tyranny* (London, 2023).



Plate 3. Shaykh Luṭf Allāh Mosque interior (Sinan Dogan).

visual, mathematical and/or linguistic construct (preferably in metal) designed to focus celestial influences on terrestrial bodies and hence subject to strict astrological and ritual regulation, amulets are a much less fussy technology: they usually consist of a magical formula inscribed on any medium to be worn on one's body for protection against the mischief of jinn or of illness, among other threats. Nor is inscription necessary; they may also simply be recited as a litany in times of need.⁴⁵ Likely the most cited and used amulets in Sufi and lettrist circles are those of Abū l-Ḥasan al-Shādhilī (d. 1258), eponym of the Shādhiliyya, particularly his Sea Litany (*ḥizb al-baḥr*) and Land Litany (*ḥizb al-barr*, aka *al-ḥizb al-kabīr*): stated by their author to be divinely and Prophetically revealed texts, both provide blanket protection while traveling – including, explicitly, out-of-body – and the first has such a decidedly lettrist tang as to induct Shādhilī into the early modern pantheon of authorities on that science.⁴⁶ In particular, the Sea Litany frequently invokes the quranic isolated letters (*muqattaʿāt*), as in these pivotal lines:

45. See e.g. M. A. Garcia Probert, P. M. Sijpesteijn, ed., *Amulets and Talismans of the Middle East and North Africa in Context: Transmission, Efficacy and Collections* (Leiden, 2022).

46. N. Gardiner, "The Occultist Encyclopedism of 'Abd al-Raḥmān al-Biṣṭāmī", *Mamlūk Studies Review* 20 (2017), pp. 3–38, esp. 19–27.

In the name of God is my gate and blesses my walls, YS is my roof, *KHY*Ꝛ my sufficiency, *HM* ꝚSQ my security! Thus shall God suffice you against them – He is the All-hearing, the All-knowing (Q. 2:137)!

There is little doubt that Mīr Dāmād too was a habitual user of these and other amuletic incantations – so habitual, in fact, that he was hypnagogically gifted, by Muḥammad and ‘Alī themselves, his very own. Given his passionate confessional commitment, its overtly Twelver tenor is unsurprising. Yet it is equally ecumenical: in tandem with ‘Alī’s supporters, the Prophet’s Companions are invoked. Such Sunni-Shi‘i occult ecumenism is perfectly consonant with Mīr Dāmād’s lettrist sources, and Maḥmūd Dihdār in particular, whose own sources are exclusively Sunni, the Imams aside.⁴⁷ What makes this *ḥizb* exceptional is its status as a *visualisation exercise* rather than a litany: the Holy Family, the Twelve Imams and the Companions are to be visualised around one’s person in their respective directions, with angels and the divine presence itself encircling. In short, it constitutes a Safavid Sphere of Protection – precisely the type of ritual that is a mainstay of modern Euro-American occult practice too.⁴⁸

The ritual-magical nature of Mīr Dāmād’s 1614 body-doffing experience is just as explicit, and likewise provoked by prayer. To understand when prayer becomes magic, when Religion becomes Science, we must turn to the genre devoted to the technological explication of that question: the grimoire. Adapted to English from French *grammaire*, “grammar”, this is a term more literally appropriate to Persianate manuals of magic than *Latin*. The early modern Christian grimoire is most often associated with goetic demon-summoning, especially of the Solomonic variety, and only sporadically kabbalistic. Its post-Mongol Islamic counterpart, by contrast, while equally Solomonic, prefers angels and jinn to demons, and its kabbalistic tenor is all-structuring: alphanumeric, quranic language as the grammar of *being* – and hence source of all *becoming*.⁴⁹

47. M. Melvin-Koushki, “Occult Ecumenism”.

48. See the articles in G. M. Martini, ed., *Visualizing Sufism*, in particular Gardiner’s “Diagrams and Visionary Experience”; for an authoritative modern formulation see J. M. Greer, *The Druid Magic Handbook: Ritual Magic Rooted in the Living Earth* (San Francisco, 2007), p. 65–78.

49. O. Davies, *Grimoires: A History of Magic Books* (Oxford, 2009); cf. M. Melvin-Koushki, “How to Rule the World: Occult-Scientific Manuals of the Early Modern Persian Cosmopolis”, *Journal of Persianate Studies* 11/2 (2018), pp. 140–154; M. Melvin-Koushki, “Shaykhi Prayer as Safavid-Qajar Occult Technology”, English introduction to Muṣṭafā b. Muḥammad

Simply put, lettrism became central to early modern Islamic occultism in a way kabbalah never became for Christian, its quranic and imamic tenor rendering most “magic” perfectly orthodox. This divergence is epitomized by two of the most popular Arabic grimoires ever produced: the astral- and natural-magical *Goal of the Sage* (*Ghāyat al-ḥakīm*), which achieved more fame in Latin as the *Picatrix*; and the *Greater Sun of Gnosés* (*Shams al-ma‘ārif al-kubrā*), thoroughly lettrist and hence untranslatable for Christian purposes (unlike Bible-based kabbalah), yet hailed the most iconic exemplar of the genre throughout premodern and modern Islamdom. Due exclusively to its Latin Christian reception, the former has been reasonably well studied by Europeanists, and is constantly invoked in the literature, while the latter – “unreceived in Europe” yet considerably more influential for a broader swath of humanity over the last half-millennium – has only begun to be addressed in modern scholarship.⁵⁰ This bizarre disproportionality in the history of occultism is testament to the continued Eurocentrism of the field, whereby only those medieval Arabic texts that happened to be done into Latin (often poorly) may serve as benchmarks for Islamic Magic, the better to render Islam itself eternally medieval. But it is also testament to a remarkable parting of theological and technological ways within the Greater Western grimoiric tradition, despite the robust Platonic, Pythagorean, Hermetic and Solomonic Islamic-Jewish-Christian parallelism that helped shape these Western early modern book cultures.

The cultural sea-change that was the post-Mongol lettrist revolution is encapsulated in the history of Illuminationist philosophy itself.

Hādī Khū‘ī (d. 1839), *Hidden Gems and Treasured Pearls*, pp. 5–31. The fame and infamy of Sirāj al-Dīn Sakkākī (d. 1229) as grammarian and grimoirist in equal measure – he helped convert his Ilkhanid patron to Islam by means of magic – is here emblematic; see E. Selove’s forthcoming four-volume edition, translation and collection of studies of his seminal grimoire, *The Comprehensive Book for Making the Complete and Perfected Human* (*Kitāb al-Shāmil wa-baḥr al-kāmil*), which marks the beginning of precisely this divergence.

50. N. Gardiner, *Esotericism in a Manuscript Culture: Aḥmad al-Būnī and His Readers through the Mamlūk Period* (PhD dissertation, University of Michigan, 2014); J.-Ch. Coulon, *La magie islamique et le corpus bunianum au Moyen Âge*, 4 vols. (PhD dissertation, University of Paris IV–Sorbonne, 2013). It is significant albeit exceptional in this context that the library of John Dee (d. 1608), imperial Pythagorean-kabbalist extraordinaire, likely contained a Būnian volume whose Arabic text he could not decipher but whose diagrams he found wondrous, as Noah Gardiner hypothesises (personal communication).

Where Suhrawardī's (and Rāzī's) technology of philosophic ascent is strictly astral-magical, an approach epitomized by the tenth- or eleventh-century *Goal of the Sage*,⁵¹ Mīr Dāmād's would seem to be primarily lettrist, as his *On Doffing* makes clear: his ritual practice centred on the *divine-name mantra*. While a practice central to Sufism too, as the primary means of realizing the saintly imperative *takhalluq bi-akhlāq Allāh*, whereby one strives to become an avatar of the Names in gradual succession, Mīr Dāmād's embrace of the same does not in some vague sense make him a Sufi. By the early seventeenth century, Safavid scholars – especially those of an occultist bent – had succeeded in disaggregating gnosis (*ʿir-fān*) from Sufism (*taṣawwuf*), while continuing to valorize Sufi authors as major sources for philosophy, occult or otherwise.⁵² Chief among these, of course, was the Andalusian Ibn al-ʿArabī – and his Ifriqiyan peer Abū l-ʿAbbās al-Būnī (d. btw. 1225–1232), renowned by the early modern era as the foremost Sufi mage of Islam. These two western, Sunni authorities together defined and programmatically redesigned lettrism, albeit in strictly esoterizing, initiatory fashion, as the highest mode of Islamic sainthood and sacral power (*walāya*). For all subsequent lettrists, their revolutionary theory and praxis was held up as proof for its status as the ultimate *imamic* science, encapsulated in Imam ʿAlī's classic epithet *Locus of Wonders* (*maẓhar al-ʿajāʾib*) – now taken as a theological-technological statement of fact by Sunni and Shiʿi alike.⁵³

In this disaggregation, that is, Safavid scholars were simply continuing systematizing fifteenth-century Timurid and Ottoman Sunni precedent, particularly that of Ibn Turka (d. 1432) and ʿAbd al-Raḥmān al-Bisṭāmī (d. 1454) respectively: the latter held up lettrism and Sufism as separate but

51. In her seminal 1996 article, “Baṭinism in al-Andalus”, Maribel Fierro's convincing identification of pseudo-Maslama al-Majrīṭī, anonymous author of the *Ghāyat al-ḥakīm* and *Rutbat al-ḥakīm*, as Maslama al-Qurtubī (d. 964) has been recently problematised by José Bellver, who has also convincingly argued for its author as instead an eleventh-century scholar (IOSOTR working group, 12 November 2021; a summary is forthcoming).
52. A. Anzali, “Mysticism” in *Iran: The Safavid Roots of a Modern Concept* (Columbia, SC, 2017); M. Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One: The Mathematicalization of the Occult Sciences in the High Persianate Tradition”, *Intellectual History of the Islamicate World* 5/1 (2017), pp. 127–199, esp. pp. 153, 165–167.
53. A case in point is the opening phrase of the *nādi* ʿAliyyan (“Call upon ʿAlī, Locus of Wonders!”) on a Safavid talismanic armband, flanked by the declaration “God's is the kingdom!” and the invocation “O Meeter of Needs!”, both of obvious political use; see M. Carey, *Meeting in Isfahan*, pp. 30–31, MS CBL Is As24.

equal paths to gnosis, while the former – a major source for Mīr Dāmād – recategorized Sufism as a lesser, preparatory discipline, together with Illuminationism, useful only as ritual precursor for lettrist ascent.⁵⁴ So inspired, Mīr Dāmād reconceptualized Suhrawardī's apophatic, experiential *knowledge by presence* (ʿilm ḥuḍūrī), Hermetically inexpressible by human language, in the same new-old Pythagorean-ʿAlid terms: language not as Derridean aporetic barrier to *gnōsis* but its Iamblichean *gateway drug*.⁵⁵

Mīr Dāmād's Body-Doffing Mantra

Theory aside, our Safavid Illuminationist philosopher's lettrist practice was explicitly textually Būnian. The intervening four centuries had seen the de-esotericizing elevation of Būnī, as noted, to the status of universal sage-mage, in his role as putative author of one of the most seminal Arabic grimoires ever produced: the *Greater Sun of Gnosēs*. Based on authentic Būnian works but with many gradual accretions, by the sixteenth century this one-stop shop of quranic, Islamic magic had coalesced under his name throughout the Persianate world, from Ottoman Anatolia to Mughal India; it has retained that status even to the colonialist present.⁵⁶

This pseudepigraphal classic was a primary source to Mīr Dāmād's primary sources of the Timurid and early Safavid era. These include Ibn Turka, foremost occult philosopher of the fifteenth century, whose systematization of lettrism as universal Pythagorean science had sweeping ramifications for the history of science and empire alike; his heir Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī (d. 1502), the celebrated Illuminationist-Ashʿari thinker of the turn of the sixteenth century, whose works became textbooks for Islamic philosophy-as-magic in both Iran and India; and ʿAlī Ṣafī b. Ḥusayn Vāʿiẓ Kāshifī (d. 1533), the Naqshbandi Sufi polymath and preacher whose practical lettrist treatises helped mainstream the science as a primary

54. M. Melvin-Koushki, "Better than Sufi Sex: Ibn Turka on the Superiority of Lettrism to Sufism as Model of Occult Islamic Humanism", in M. Olzi, L. Pizzighella, ed., *Islam ed esoterismo/Islam and Esotericism*, special issue of *La Rosa di Paracelso* 2 (2020 [2022]), pp. 53–80; M. Melvin-Koushki, "World as (Arabic) Text"; N. Gardiner, "Occultist Encyclopedism".

55. M. Melvin-Koushki, "Of Islamic Grammarology".

56. N. Gardiner, "Esotericism"; M. Melvin-Koushki, J. Pickett, "Mobilizing Magic: Occultism in Central Asia and the Continuity of High Persianate Culture under Russian Rule", *Studia Islamica* 111/2 (2016), pp. 231–284.

Timurid Sunni means of Shi'izing Safavid Iran. They were an inspiration in turn to Maḥmūd Dihdār, passionate Twelver lettrist and Shaykh Bahāʾī's teacher, whose oeuvre is even more thoroughlygoingly Būnian.⁵⁷

To understand the ritual-magical nature of the divine-name mantra that drove the wondrous, vertiginous, overwhelming cosmic vision Mīr Dāmād records in his *On Doffing*, then, we must turn to the *Greater Sun of Gnosés* itself. At least 57 manuscript copies of this grimoire survive in Iran today, many of which were produced before his death.⁵⁸ (This is in contrast to the *Goal of the Sage*, with only 11 copies, most late and many partial.) That it is based at core on Būnī's authentic treatise *Sun of Gnosés and Subtle Bounties* (*Shams al-ma'ārif wa-laṭā'if al-ʿawārif*) – featuring some of the most innovative, esoteric and initiatory mind-altering diagrams of the pre-Mongol lettrist tradition – likewise makes it the immediate context for Mīr Dāmād's own body-doffing visualization-incantation technology.⁵⁹

As he tells us, the engine of this particular accession (one of many) was the mantra *O All-sufficient, O All-sufficer* (*yā ghanī yā mughnī*)! But how to utilize these two Names, and what are their experiential effects? True to form, pseudo-Būnī combines cosmic theory with mundane practice as follows:

On His name the All-sufficient (*ghani*): Whoso multiplies its ritual repetition until one of his realms resonates therewith wholly, God shall free him of the need for all but Him. This mantra is particularly suited to novices. The All-sufficient is a name pertaining to the assumption of a divine trait (*takhalluq*), while the All-sufficer (*mughnī*) pertains to the realization of the divine nature itself (*taḥaqquq*).

57. M. Melvin-Koushki, "World as (Arabic) Text"; M. Melvin-Koushki, "Qizilbash Magic"; M. Melvin-Koushki, "Occult Ecumenism".

58. Muṣṭafā Dirāyātī, *Fihristigān-i nuskhā-hā-yi khaṭṭī-yi Īrān* (FaNKhA) (Tehran, 1390 Sh./2011).

59. N. Gardiner, "Diagrams and Visionary Experience". As Bink Hallum notes ("New Light on Early Arabic *Awfāq* Literature", in L. Saif et al., ed., *Islamicate Occult Sciences in Theory and Practice* [Leiden, 2021], pp. 57–161, esp. 69), Indic magic squares – a source for the much more robust Islamic science – came to be used by the eleventh century as tantric ritual diagrams (sg. *yantra*) for visualisation purposes. On cognate Jewish and Christian visualisation practices see e.g. J. H. Chajes, *The Kabbalistic Tree* (University Park, Pennsylvania, 2022); C. Fanger, ed., *Invoking Angels: Theurgic Ideas and Practices, Thirteenth to Sixteenth Centuries* (University Park, Pennsylvania, 2012); C. Fanger, *Rewriting Magic: An Exegesis of the Visionary Autobiography of a Fourteenth-Century French Monk* (University Park, Pennsylvania, 2015).

[The first] has the value 1,007 when spoken and 1,006 when written. As for its spoken value, it forms an evenly odd [square] without remainder with the constant 128, connecting to the Names the Out-spreader (*bāsiṭ*), the Possessed of Majesty (*dhū l-jalāl*). As for its written value, it forms an evenly odd [square] with remainder with the constant 274, which added to its root gives the Most High's Name the Enumerator (*muḥṣī*); its associated square is of great benefit, as all seekers of the greater wealth know. This is its form:⁶⁰

257	275	221	264
608	223	258	271
266	394	364	359
273	268	391	261

On His name the All-sufficer (*mughni*): Whoso multiplies its ritual repetition, God shall facilitate his goal. And whoso writes it and carries it while repeating the name according to its letters' value [1,100], then reciting the Sura of Forenoon, then praying: "O God! Ease my way as You have eased the way of so many of Your servants before me, and by Your grace free me of need for any but You!", persisting in this for 40 days, God will dispatch a messenger to inform him – either awake or asleep – of what he desires, according to the measure of his endeavour.

I once described this mantra and procedure to a friend, who then undertook it in isolation (*khalwa*), ritually repeating this name for an extended period – and God did indeed facilitate his goal, bringing him everything he needed by way of gold and dirhams. He was also [divinely] told: "The more you increase [repetition of this name], the more I will increase you, and whenever you consider it sufficient, I will suffice you". As stated the Proof of Islam [Ghazālī] in his *Resurrection (Iḥyā')*: "Whoso adds after the Friday prayer this prayer – 'O God! O All-sufficient, O Praised, O Initiator, O Returner, O Performer of all You will, O Ever-merciful, O Loving, suffice me

60. As is frequently the case in manuscript and lithograph copies, this square and the two following are garbled in the sources available to me, often for deliberately esotericising, initiatory purposes as a test of the reader's aptitude, and hence ineffective for the operation in question.

by replacing my forbidden acts with permitted ones and my rebellious acts with obedient ones, and with You alone apart from all others!' – 70 times and persisting therein, God shall make him rich".⁶¹ Writing and carrying the same guarantees profit in trade.

Know that the secrets and lights of the Names traverse the Earth and reveal all that is in her; they break divine habit [to produce miracles] and open wisdom within the heart. Said the Most High: *God has the most beautiful names – call Him by them* (Q. 7:180); and: *Call upon Me and I will answer you* (Q. 40:60). And said [the Prophet] (peace be upon him): *Invocation (du'ā') profits with what has been sent down and what has yet to be*; and: *Invocation is the believer's weapon*; and: *Whoso has had the gate of invocation opened to him, the gates of its answering open to him also*; and: *God is angered [only] by those who have not invoked Him*; and: *God will not be impatient with you until you are impatient with Him*.

[This Name's] value is 1,100, the same as His Name Possessed of Majesty and Grace (*dhū l-jalāl wa-l-ikrām*), for this attribute of the Most High is one of beauty [rather than of majesty]. When calculated according to its letternames, however, its value is 5,367, connecting to the two Names of majesty the Compeller (*jabbār*), the Overtaker (*mukawwir*). This is its square, as you can see:

M	Gh	N	Y
51	9	41	99
8	48	102	220
101	43	7	49

61. This appears to be a later expansion of Ghazālī's original version in the section on the secrets of prayer (*asrār al-ṣalāt*), where it is styled a protective amulet (*ḥirz*) against Satan; see *Ihyā' 'ulūm al-dīn*, ed. Sayyid b. Ibrāhīm Abī Ḥafṣ, 5 vols. (Cairo, 1419/1998), 1, p. 262. It is cited in 'Abd Allāh b. As'ad al-Yāfī'ī, *al-Durr al-naẓīm fī khawāṣṣ al-Qur'ān al-karīm* (Beirut, 1424/2004), p. 25; and, tellingly, in the pseudepigraphal *Mujarrabāt Ibn Sīnā al-rūḥāniyya* (Beirut, 1425/2005), p. 199. As I note elsewhere, "a comparison of Mīr Dāmād's lettrist works with their sources shows him to be singlehandedly responsible for the Neopythagoreanization of Ibn Sīnā himself, the second Aristotle – an unprecedented transmogrification that epitomizes the project of much of Safavid philosophy as a distinctive unit" (M. Melvin-Koushki, "World as (Arabic) Text", p. 391).

While there is little doubt Mīr Dāmād enjoyed access to the *Greater Sun*, another source is even more proximate: ‘Alī Ṣafī’s *Amulet of Protection from the Trials of Time* (*Hirz al-amān min fitan al-zamān*). With Dihdār’s one of the most comprehensive manuals of applied lettrism of the sixteenth century, and unlike Dihdār’s a Safavid bestseller, over a hundred manuscript copies survive in Iran alone. It draws exclusively on Sunni sources for the benefit of a Shi‘i audience, and is arranged in a 5–5–12 pattern in honour of the Folk of the Mantle and the Twelve Imams to that end. The *Greater Sun* is constantly cited, together with ‘Abd Allāh b. As‘ad al-Yāfi‘ī’s (d. 1367) *Strung Pearl* (*al-Durr al-naẓīm*) and Abū Ya‘qūb al-Kūmī’s (fl. 1407) *Easing Aims* (*Taysīr al-maṭālib*), as well as a range of preeminent medieval and early modern authorities, from Ghazālī and Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī to Ibn Turka.

On the divine name All-sufficient, ‘Alī Ṣafī paraphrases this passage from Ibn Turka’s *Query of Kings* (*Su‘l al-mulūk*) – likewise primarily concerned with sociopolitics:⁶²

One of the leading authorities on this art reported as follows: There was a certain dervish out West who went to sit in the corner of a mosque, and there trained his will on the qiblah of total focus, then started reciting with purest sincerity *O All-sufficient (yā ghani)!* He continued in this manner, totally devoid of doubt and care, until he reached 1,071 repetitions – whereupon a corner of the mosque suddenly caved in. He ran to it, astonished and amazed, and discovered a purse of a thousand gold pieces that had been hidden there in the dirt [from the wall] that fell! This [oral] form [alone] thus greatly conduces to an improvement of one’s political and financial prospects, and the renown that attends.

And on the divine name All-sufficer, he quotes Kūmī to a similarly pecuniary end:

The author of *Easing Aims* states: Whoever recites this Name daily according to its gematrical value as written, which is to say 1,100 times, or according to its differentiated value accounting for the letter names spelled out, which is to say 1,267 times, the Real Most Exalted and High shall make him powerful and without need. The same author states: This noble Name has



62. See the full edition and translation in my forthcoming *The Lettrist Treatises of Ibn Turka*.

a magic square; for whomever bears it [as a talisman] on their person while ritually multiplying its repetition according to either calculation, the effects of wealth will manifest even more quickly, perfectly and completely.⁶³

<i>M</i>	<i>Gh</i>	<i>N</i>	<i>Y</i>
40	1000	50	10
11	49	39	1001
998	38	12	52
51	13	999	37

As court philosopher and Chief Jurisconsult (*shaykh al-islām*) of the Safavid empire, Mīr Dāmād was very well off indeed – and also famously fat; clearly his habitual use of this particular Būnian mantra had the desired worldly effect! But such mantras are routinely presented as profiting their user in matters secular and religious, this-worldly and otherworldly, physical and spiritual simultaneously. Mind and body here figure not as binary but as circuit, each empowering or healing the other.

To this end, the ritual preparations prescribed in early modern Arabo-Persian grimoires are the same regardless of the sublimity or mundanity of one's objective: all letter-magical operations require the purification of mind and body in tandem, failing which they simply will not work, or may even backfire.⁶⁴ A comprehensive, simplified list of 44 prerequisites is helpfully provided by 'Alī Ṣafī at the end of his own summary of *Amulet of Protection*, of which 24 are general and the remainder specific to recitation or inscription respectively. The general prerequisites include: 1) find an experienced teacher; 2) make your intention clear; 3) concentrate fully on the operation; 4) reduce food intake; 5) eat only licit foods;

63. 'A. Ṣafī, *Ḥirz al-amān*, Tehran, MS Majlis 15708/1, p. 168; Tehran, MS Majlis 708, ff. 139b-140a. The correct version given here is in the latter manuscript, copied in the seventeenth century. Cf. Mīr Dāmād's more generic reference to the first Name at *Jazavāt*, p. 238.

64. See e.g. M. Melvin-Koushki, "Shaykhi Prayer", p. 13; on Hermetic precedent see W. J. Hanegraaff, *Hermetic Spirituality*, p. 111.

6) fast during operation days; 7) avoid smoked foods after breaking your fast; 8) give charity; 9) maintain a vegan diet during operations; 10) avoid eating pungent vegetables of the allium family to prevent bad breath; 11) maintain ritual purity; 12) clean and perfume your clothes; 13) wear only licit clothes; 14) clean and perfume your operation site; 15) ensure that your operation site is a legal one; 16) adhere to auspicious times, whether Prophetic or astrological; 17) maintain solitude, and avoid commoners, women, children and the insane in particular; 18) always face the qiblah; 19) suffumigate the operation's product; 20) repeat the operation until it is successful; 21) be patient if the result is delayed; 22) do not speak of the operation to anyone, whether friend or stranger; 23) begin and end every operation by invoking God; 24) begin and end every operation by blessing the Prophet.⁶⁵

This, then, is the grimoiric, ritual-magical context for pseudo-Būnī's equation of the name All-sufficient with *takhalluq*, involving virtuous and rigorous body and behaviour modifications, but also cash profit – which is to say, in-body philosophy; and All-sufficer with *taḥaqquq*, cosmic realisation of the Real (*ḥaqq*) – which is to say, out-of-body philosophy. It is precisely such a direct, experiential and indeed traumatic realisation of *being as infinite poverty-as-wealth* that Mīr Dāmād records in *On Doffing*.

Their stage thus set, my translations of his famous two visionary accounts follow.

An Amuletic Incantation

Qom, Ramaḍān 1011/February-March 1603:

Among the loveliest of the raptures (*ikhtilās*) and snatchings away (*ikhtiṭāf*) I have experienced, this by sheer divine effluxion and grace (be He glorified and His rule glorious), [was the following]: One afternoon in the supreme Month of God, [Ramaḍān], in the year 1011 since the Prophet's holy and blessed emigration, I was in the City of Faith, the preserve of the Members of the House of God's Messenger (God bless him and them), the divinely protected Qom, secure against all of time's calamities, when an accession of sleepiness overcame me like a seizure (*khulsa*) while I was sitting facing the qiblah just after the afternoon prayer. I was shown as

65. This summary version is his *Tuḥfa-yi Majdiyya*, presented and edited in M. Melvin-Koushki, "Qizilbash Magic"; cf. the more extensive, astrologically specific treatment in 'A. Ṣafī, *Ḥirz al-amān*, Tehran, MS Majlis 15708/1, pp. 62–99 (book 1, chapters 2–5).

I drowsed a scintillating and most splendiferous light in the form of a human reclining on his right arm, and another of piercing brilliance and majesty of similarly staggering awesomeness sitting upright behind the first. It was as if I spontaneously knew or was somehow informed that the figure reclining was the Commander of the Faithful (God bless and keep him most securely) and the figure sitting to his back was our lord and intercessor the Messenger of God (God bless and keep him), with me kneeling immediately before the first.

I then saw him (God bless and keep him most securely) smile at me in the kindest way possible and run his blessed hand over my face, from brow to cheek to beard, to comfort me and to remove from my soul all sorrow and heal the brokenness of my heart and cleanse my mind of all sadness – whereupon I applied myself to him with the amuletic invocation (*ḥirz*) my hearing received and my soul seized. For he commanded me, *Recite thusly or thusly recite*:

Muḥammad, the Messenger of God (God bless and keep him), is before me; Fāṭima, daughter of the Messenger of God (God bless her), is above my head; the Commander of the Faithful, ‘Alī son of Abū Ṭālib, Legatee of the Messenger of God (God bless and keep him), is to my right; al-Ḥasan and al-Ḥusayn and ‘Alī and Muḥammad and Ja‘far and Mūsā and ‘Alī and Muḥammad and ‘Alī and al-Ḥasan and the Awaited Proof, my Imams (God bless and keep them all), are to my left; Abū Dharr and Salmān and al-Miqdād and Ḥudhayfa and ‘Ammār and the Companions of the Messenger of God (God bless and keep him, and God Most High be pleased with them all) are behind me; the angels (peace be upon them) are all about me; and God (whose affair is exalted and whose Names are hallowed) encompasses and keeps and preserves me! *For God is behind them all, encompassing! Nay, it is a glorious Qur’an, in a tablet preserved.*⁶⁶ *And God is the best keeper and the most merciful of the merciful!*⁶⁷

Having communicated to me the whole, he (peace be upon him) commanded me: *Repeat [after me]!* and he recited it and I recited it precisely after him (God bless him). Then he commanded: *Repeat it to me again in full!* I did so, and each time I finished it he made me repeat it again until I had memorised it perfectly. Thereupon I started from my sleepiness, adoring [this accession] most ardently and passionately – as shall I do until the Day of Resurrection!



66. Q. 85:20–22.

67. Q. 12:64.

'Twas [this sleep] that was true waking – for the masses to wake is to sleep;
it was pure life – by comparison their life is mere death.

These letters were inscribed as mere approximate report by the poor and
perishing fingers of the most wretched of the ruled and the most needy
of the mercy of his Lord the Praised and All-sufficient, Muḥammad son of
Muḥammad, called al-Bāqir al-Dāmād al-Ḥusaynī, God grant him utmost
beauty in his abodes twain!⁶⁸

On Doffing

Isfahan?, 16 Shaʿbān 1023/19 September 1614:⁶⁹

In the name of God, All-merciful, Ever-merciful. The totality of praise be to God,
Lord of all worlds, and His blessings be upon our master Muḥammad and
the pure members of his House!

Upon a day in this our present month – Friday, the sixteenth of the Proph-
et's blessed month of Shaʿbān of the 1023rd year since his holy emigra-
tion – I was engaged in one of my private meditations in remembrance
of my Lord wherein I multiply the mention of His Names, in this case the
All-sufficient (*al-ghani*). I became wholly rapt from all things in the ritual
repetition of *O All-sufficient, O All-sufficer (yā ghanī yā mughnī)*, captive to
the sanctum of His secret and extinguished in the rays of His light – when
lo: it was as if a holy bolt of lightning struck me and snatched (*ijtidhāb*)
me from my bodily abode!

Having torn out the throat of the trap that is physical sensation and undone
the knots of the net that is nature, I soared through the sky of the psychi-
cal realm (*malakūt*) of reality on the wings of my mind (*rūʿ*). It was as if I
had doffed my body and abjured my home and shed my form and cleaved
to my spirit (*khalad*) alone. I passed beyond the clime of time (*zamān*) and
arrived at the realm of meta-time (*dahr*) – whereupon I found myself in
the capital of being (*miṣr al-wujūd*) itself, athrong with all the nations of
its total order: things created and engendered, spiritual and natural, holy
and primal, timefree and timebound. There too were all peoples faithful
and faithless, benighted and enlightened, men and women of the past

68. *Muṣannafāt-i Mīr Dāmād*, 1, pp. 632–633 (Persian trans. pp. 633–634); Jahānbakhsh,
Muʿallim-i sālis, pp. 158–159; see also M. Mūsavi, *Ḥakīm-i Astarābād*, p. 139.

69. Following later biobibliographical sources, the editor identifies its date of composition
as not as 14 but 16 Shaʿbān. Corbin, however, dwells at some length on the symbolic
significance of the number 14 in his discussion of this treatise, while ignoring its ritual-
magical context (H. Corbin, *En Islam iranien*, IV, pp. 40–43).

and of the future, the ancients and the moderns, all together in eternity without beginning or end (*azal, abad*) – a grand assemblage of all individual possibilities and atoms of the realms of contingency (*imkān*) in their numberless masses, lowly and great, persisting and perishing, present and future, a single glorious procession of groups as an infinitely diverse whole. And all were fixing the face of their essences (*mahiyyāt*) on His glorious gate and the gaze of their quiddities (*anniyyāt*) on His sublime court without knowing, all were with the language of the poverty of their needy beings (*dhawāt*) and the tongue of the want of their perishing ipseities (*huwiyyāt*) raising an overwhelming clamour of supplication, invoking Him, imploring Him, crying to Him, ritually repeating *O All-sufficient, O All-sufficer!* all unawares.

Engulfed by this clamour filling the realm Noetic and this cry pervading the Unseen, I instantly prostrated myself, wonderstruck, and from sheer astonishment nearly forgot my own noetic essence and saw not my own individual soul! I had escaped the nightland of engendered existence (*kawn*) and exited the region of being headlong.

Then suddenly this accession left me and the abduction (*khulsa*) ceased, leaving me consumed by longing violent and extreme, and to the land of perdition and the province of destruction and the district of deception and the village of illusion I returned, unwillingly, again.⁷⁰

Out-of-Body Experience (OBE) as Ritual Trauma

[The vision of the good] illuminates to the extent that one capable of receiving the influence of intellectual splendor can receive it [...] Those able to drink somewhat more deeply of the vision often fall asleep, moving out of the body toward a sight most fair, just as it happened to Ouranos and Kronos, our ancestors.

*Corpus Hermeticum X*⁷¹

In its ritual-magical fixation on out-of-body experience of meta-time, Mīr Dāmād's philosophy might seem "mystical" to the modern reader, or even New Age – that diffuse yet coherent Euro-American cultural movement whose late twentieth-century florescence continues to generate



70. *Muṣannafāt-i Mīr Dāmād*, 1, pp. 634–636; *Jahānbakhsh, Mu'allim-i sālis*, pp. 157–158; see also M. Mūsavī, *Ḥakīm-i Astarābād*, pp. 139–140.

71. B. P. Copenhaver, trans., *Hermetica: The Greek Corpus Hermeticum and the Latin Asclepius in a New English Translation, with Notes and Introduction* (Cambridge, 1992), p. 31.

bumper crops of books on “astral projection”, virtually all of which promise both high weirdness and the blissful, direct experience of timeloose reality.⁷² Roughly translated in his own early modern terms, Mīr Dāmād may perhaps be styled a New Ager. Our early modern philosopher is emphatic as to the superiority of the Moderns to the Ancients on the question of becoming in and beyond time, and equally emphatic as to the scientific validity and technological applications of his experientialist approach: Islam is the New Age. At the same time, his Twelver Shi‘i commitment is passionate and unswerving, and his philhellenic, perennialist Illuminatism is no critique of the “Western tradition” – Pythagorean-Platonic-Solomonic-Hermetic – but its Islamic apotheosis as Enlightenment.⁷³

So much for culture; what of physiology? Here Mīr Dāmād’s evocative yet precise accounts accord nicely with the findings of modern parapsychology. Coined by G. N. M. Tyrell in 1943, the term “out-of-body experience” or simply OBE has since superseded “travelling clairvoyance” and “astral projection” as a more neutral descriptor.⁷⁴ Recent manuals emphasise the empirical nature of the phenomenon:

An out-of-body experience (OBE) involves coherent feelings, impressions, and sensory awareness of total separation from your physical body in the

72. See e.g. E. Davis, *High Weirdness: Drugs, Esoterica and Visionary Experience in the Seventies* (London and Cambridge, MA, 2019); S. L. Treasure, “Out-of-Body Experiences in the Screen Age”, in J. Hunter, ed., *Deep Weird: The Varieties of High Strangeness Experience* (Milton Keynes, 2023), pp. 89–112.

73. On Mīr Dāmād’s Enlightenment ethos as epitome of early modernity see M. Melvin-Koushki, “*Tahqīq* vs. *Taqlīd* in the Renaissances of Western Early Modernity”, *Philological Encounters* 3/1 (2018), pp. 193–249; on the New Age ethos as “popular western culture criticism expressed in terms of a secularized esotericism” see W. J. Hanegraaff, *New Age Religion and Western Culture: Esotericism in the Mirror of Secular Thought* (Leiden, 1996). As with “Renaissance” and “Scientific Revolution,” that modern historiography awards this capitalized term solely to a relatively small cluster of seventeenth- and eighteenth-century West European thinkers is a classic colonialist tic. Not only is “Enlightenment” the most precise translation of *Ishrāq* based on its early modern adherents’ consciously modernizing usage, but its Islamic iteration was also defined by an Occult-Scientific Revolution, as we have seen, whose emphatically Pythagorean, Hermetic and Solomonic tenor defined the thought of Mīr Dāmād’s Christian contemporaries (or near-contemporaries) Bruno and Bacon, Kepler and Newton too. See M. Melvin-Koushki, “Is (Islamic) Occult Science Science?”

74. G. N. M. Tyrell, *Apparitions* (London, 1943); C. Green, *Out-of-the-Body Experiences* (London, 1968); R. Monroe, *Journeys Out of the Body* (Garden City, NY, 1971).

form of an independent consciousness, whilst usually still being able to see and reason. The experience often involves perceiving the body from above, travel over distances, and sometimes interaction with others. The OBE can also lead to what appear to be other levels of reality. The OBE is generally described as “being as real as everyday reality.”⁷⁵

While utterly common across cultures and eras, however, OBEs seem to require a trick: *physical and psychological trauma*. In modern Euro-American reports (few by practising philosophers), such experiences can be unintentionally and spontaneously instigated by everything from exhaustion to nightmare, stroke to cardiac arrest; the near-death experience (NDE) is its ultimate and often most spectacular form.⁷⁶ Simply put: the greater the natural trauma, the better the empirical data. Laboratory studies of such paranormal states yield less impressive, though still statistically significant, results, given current ethical restraints against intentionally traumatising human subjects to the degree necessary to jolt soul from body. (Needless to say, no such restraints apply to nonhuman persons, whether plant or animal, or, until very recently, to non-white humans: the modern lab as trauma chamber unto death.) Here the clinical art lies in generating a non-harmful level of artificial trauma, using everything from sensory deprivation tanks to meditation to psychedelics. The same rule applies to premodern grimoiric experimentation. From veganism,

75. G. Nicholls, *Navigating the Out-of-Body Experience: Radical New Techniques* (Woodbury, MN, 2012), p. 5.

76. See e.g. J. Schlieter, *What Is It Like to Be Dead? Near-Death Experiences, Christianity, and the Occult* (Oxford, 2018); A. Delorme, D. Radin, H. Wabbe, “Advancing the Evidence for Survival of Consciousness”, Bigelow Institute for Consciousness Studies Essay Contest (unpublished paper, 2021); D. Radin, *Real Magic: Ancient Wisdom, Modern Science, and a Guide to the Secret Power of the Universe* (New York, 2018); E. F. Kelly, A. Crabtree, P. Marshall, ed., *Beyond Physicalism: Toward Reconciliation of Science and Spirituality* (New York, 2015), esp. chapters 2 (P. Marshall, “Mystical Experiences”), 7 (B. Carr, “Hyperspatial Models”); and 8 (G. Shaw, “Platonic Siddhas”). Particularly apropos to Mīr Dāmād’s meta-time project is Marshall’s observation (45) as to “the intimate connections between mystical and psi phenomena”, such that “the veridicality of psi is open to relatively straightforward investigation” and that “mystical experiences sometimes appear to furnish insights into the natural world, such as the coexistence of past, present, and future, and the existence of holistic interconnections between things”.

fasting and sleep deprivation to mantras, visualisations and plant drugs: all are time-honoured means for ritually, artificially traumatising mind and body simultaneously to reliably induce paranormality.⁷⁷

Recent brain-imaging studies provide robust confirmation of the efficacy of such ritual procedures, ancient and modern. In sharp contrast to “normal” states of consciousness, wherein quantitative brain activity closely correlates with qualitative, subjective experience, dramatic *decreases* in brain activity common to psychedelic use and various forms of natural and artificial trauma closely correlate instead with dramatic *increases* in the richness of subjective experience – and especially feelings of self-transcendence, light- and love-drenched or otherwise. One stroke patient’s description is here deliciously Islamically apropos: you feel like a genie finally freed from the bottle! To make sense of such bizarre clinical data, some philosophers have again begun to argue – in openly Platonic, idealist terms – for body-doffing as dissociation as cosmic principle.⁷⁸

Reread in this parapsychological and neuroscientific context, Mīr Dāmād’s accounts are precisely *psychedelic*, and the quest for theosis (*taʿalluh*) they record ritual-magically *entheogenic*.⁷⁹ As explicitly reported, his experience of 1603 was a classic instance of visionary hypnagogia, the

77. J. J. Kripal, *Secret Body: Erotic and Esoteric Currents in the History of Religions* (Chicago, 2017). On the Hellenic context see e.g. P. T. Struck, *Divination and Human Nature: A Cognitive History of Intuition in Classical Antiquity* (Princeton, 2016); P. T. Struck, *Birth of the Symbol: Ancient Readers at the Limits of Their Texts* (Princeton, 2004), chapters 6, 7. For a corrective reading of Iamblichean theurgy see W. J. Hanegraaff, *Hermetic Spirituality*, pp. 99–118; G. Shaw, *Hellenic Tantra*.

78. See e.g. B. Kastrup, *Science Ideated: The Fall of Matter and the Contours of the Next Mainstream Scientific Worldview* (Winchester, 2021), chapters 25, 27. By this argument, what we seem to experience as “normal,” individual consciousness is a dissociated alter of universal consciousness as ground of all being and becoming. The condition now termed dissociative identity disorder (DID) – likely a form of self-hypnosis in response to childhood trauma – is thus no disorder, but rather an aperture onto something more closely approaching reality. Dreaming, DID sufferers can experience several alters simultaneously; waking, shifting between alters can cause dramatic physiological changes: allergic reactions, musculature, body shape, handedness, vision and gender often differ between personalities. In early modern terms, such feats of mind over matter are *real magic*, making “dissociation” an unexpectedly accurate modern translation of *tajrīd*.

79. On Platonic-Pythagorean *taʿalluh* as guiding theme in early modern Islamic philosophy see e.g. S. Rizvi, “New Sociopolitical Formations and the ‘Renaissance’ of Philosophy”, in A. Salvatore et al., ed., *The Wiley-Blackwell History of Islam* (Hoboken, NJ, 2018), pp. 393–412, esp. 396, 405.

liminal state between waking and sleeping we all experience daily, but cultivated by clairvoyants and psychonauts as an ideal gateway to out-of-body experience of “deep time” and the “more real than real”.⁸⁰ Clearly Mīr Dāmād too was alert to the revelatory possibilities of the hypnagogic state, or what he terms “sleepiness like a seizure” (*sina shibh khulsa*); one gets the impression he often drowsed after ritual prayer to that end.⁸¹ In corroboration, modern controlled research has shown the hypnagogic vision to be most qualitatively similar to the DMT vision, equally cosmic but with more machine elves – pregnantly described by psychedelics pioneer Terence McKenna (d. 2000) as “syntactical creatures made of language”.⁸²

A Pythagorean lettrist rather than a DMT psychonaut, Mīr Dāmād ritually visualised and embodied language itself – qur’anic Arabic – as the most reliable means of tripping to the supernal realms unseen and mapping the structure of the cosmos.⁸³ True to the rules of the DMT trip, however, his

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80. R. Strassman, *DMT and the Soul of Prophecy: A New Science of Spiritual Revelation in the Hebrew Bible* (Rochester, VT, 2014), pp. 54, 201, 217–224; Ch. M. Bache, *LSD and the Mind of the Universe: Diamonds from Heaven* (Rochester, VT, 2019), chapters 5, 10. Needless to say, Bache’s descriptors “deep time” and “diamond luminosity” precisely correspond to Mīr Dāmād’s “meta-time” and “the Light”.
 81. Cf. J. Dumpert, *Liminal Dreaming: Exploring Consciousness at the Edge of Sleep* (Berkeley, CA, 2019). On sleeplike seizures as a primary path to Hermetic gnōsis see Ch. H. Bull, *The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus: The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a Teacher of Hellenized Wisdom* (Leiden, 2018), pp. 97, 238–239, 257–258, 267, 359–361, 418.
 82. Ch. Hayes, ed., *Tripping: An Anthology of True-Life Psychedelic Adventures* (New York, 2000), p. 425. The passage in full: “The secret that DMT is trying to tell us is either that language is only the tip of the iceberg that we need to discover, or that language is in the process of transforming itself. These entities seem to be syntactical creatures made of language. In that other world, everything has the quality of a brilliant pun. Now, the magic of a pun is not that it means one thing and also another thing; it’s that it simultaneously means both things at once. In the ontology of this world, that’s impossible. In that world, it’s given. To verbalize the way things really are in the DMT reality, you need a language in which every word is a multiple pun [...] What the DMT tykes are offering is the opinion that ‘you shouldn’t assign sounds to meaning. You should give it visibility’.” On McKenna see especially E. Davis, *High Weirdness*. On DMT and its peculiar efficacy in inducing Mīr Dāmādian experiences of meta-time and hyperspace – whereby one “becomes a transparent electric ghost deciphering mystoglyphs for eternity” – see G. St John, *Mystery School in Hyperspace: A Cultural History of DMT* (Berkeley, CA, 2015), esp. p. 6.
 83. The fact that DMT naturally occurs in the human and mammalian brain, however, as well as in various plants, and its production can be significantly increased by means of natural and artificial trauma (including birth and death), here suggests Mīr Dāmād as a DMT psychonaut too. The same observation applies to the prophets of the Hebrew

1614 ecsomatic experience, induced by divine-name mantra, was much more vertiginous, exhilarating and terrifying in equal measure. Yet the traumatically experiential data it provided only confirmed the scientific salience of his signature philosophy of meta-time. Perpetual becoming (*ḥudūth dahri*), he argues, must henceforth be understood and explored in lettrist terms, both theoretically and practically, philosophically and magically.

Mīr Dāmād's visionary accounts are thus name-droppingly Hermetic in their Illuminationist commitment to out-of-body *gnōsis*. Yet their world-hating tone would seem to be equally classically Gnostic: life is but a bad dream from which we must forcibly awaken. This Hermetic-Gnostic tension may, however, be resolved by recourse to mainstream Islamic dream theory, whereby to sleep, and especially to dream, is by definition to have an OBE. Various hadiths declare the veridical dream-vision (*ru'yā ṣāliha*) to be the gold standard, indeed a fraction of prophecy itself.⁸⁴ Hence oneiromancy (*'ilm-i ta'bīr*) as a mainstay of imperial occult science, particularly in the early modern Persianate world, per pseudo-Aristotle's advice to Alexander: the timeloose dream state as both science and spycraft.⁸⁵ Nor has it gone out of fashion even in the most traumatically colonised Islamic societies today, heirs to Freudian-Jungian psychoanalysis, which pairs well, weirdly enough, with Islamic Magic.⁸⁶ Dreaming remains fundamental to modern Science too, having prompted watershed, Nobel-winning discoveries, despite the reluctance of history of science textbooks to admit to that basic fact.⁸⁷ To dream is – potentially, under ritual conditions – to know in time and beyond it.

Bible, most of whom experienced revelation as trauma (R. Strassman, *DMT*), as well as surviving “shamanic” cultures more generally (D. Pinchbeck, *Breaking Open the Head: A Psychedelic Journey into the Heart of Contemporary Shamanism* [New York, 2002]).

84. Fractions vary from one-ninetieth to one-twenty-fourth, but one-forty-sixth is standard; see A. Mittermeier, *Dreams That Matter: Egyptian Landscapes of the Imagination* (Berkeley, CA, 2011).
85. On its Safavid politicization see N. Aḥmadī, *Ru'yā u siyāsāt dar 'aṣr-i Ṣafavī* (Tehran, 1388 Sh./2009).
86. O. El Shakry, *The Arabic Freud: Psychoanalysis and Islam in Modern Egypt* (Princeton NJ, 2017); A. Mittermeier, *Dreams That Matter*; A. Doostdar, *The Iranian Metaphysicals: Explorations in Science, Islam, and the Uncanny* (Princeton NJ, 2018).
87. J. J. Kripal, *The Flip: Epiphanies of Mind and the Future of Knowledge* (New York, 2019). Note that clinical studies show a sharp distinction in brain activity between normal dreaming, which is easily trackable, even predictable, and hypnagogic dreaming, which is mostly untrackable and more akin to psychedelic experience.

The traumatically in-body philosophy that is decoloniality must similarly be dreamed. Here Imam Khomeini (d. 1989), founder of the Islamic Republic of Iran, and steeped in Safavid thought, comes off as a specifically Mīr Dāmādian dreamer. His famous *Unveiling Secrets (Kashf-i asrār)* of 1944 – not unlike Dihdār's work of the same title, which similarly lays out a full Twelver Sunni-Shi'i occult philosophy as practised by Mīr Dāmād – is a passionate attack on twentieth-century anticlerical reformist and salafist materialism. To this end, however, Khomeini marries Pythagoras, Plato and Aristotle (Plotinus) to Ibn Sīnā, Suhrawardī, Mullā Ṣadrā and even Descartes to contemporary Spiritualism, Mesmerism and parapsychology to assert the pursuit of out-of-body experience to be the central and perennial philosophic, and scientific, practice – always to be pursued in tandem with in-body philosophy as a technology of empire. There can be no decolonialism, he declares, without *gnōsis*.⁸⁸

Conclusion: Toward a Shi'i Occult Rationalism

*Transporting passion turns the fire in my nature into the water
of life, wineworship frees me from religion and irreligion alike.*

*The One who manifests and occults beauty and passion
has cast my manifest and my occult upon the wind.*

Tell me, O Enlightenment: can our pain ever be repaid?

Yes, yes – my business of transport puts paid to that job!

Mīr Dāmād⁸⁹

For Mīr Dāmād, committed Neoplatonist and Neopythagorean, true philosophy must be simultaneously embodied and disembodied, must marry mind to matter and heaven to earth, through ritual, visionary, lettrist practice: the theosised sage-mage as *talisman*. Nor is this Illuminationist trope to be understood in merely figurative, “mystical” or otherworldly terms: talismanry, classed by Safavid encyclopedists specifically as a mathematical and hence rational-noetic (*‘aqlī*) science, was a

88. *Kashf-i asrār* (Tehran [1944]), pp. 31–37; see A. Doostdar, *Iranian Metaphysics*, pp. 117–118. Dihdār's treatise is translated in M. Melvin-Koushki, “Occult Ecumenism”.

89. Selected lines from ghazal *‘ishq ātash dar mizāj-am āb-i ḥayavān karda-ast: Dīvān-i Ishraq*, ed. S. Pūstīndūz, intro. J. Jahānbakhsh (Tehran, 1385 Sh./2006), pp. 51–52. Mīr Dāmād's total commitment to Illuminationist – that is to say, Enlightenment – philosophy is signified by his unusually nominal rather than adjectival choice of penname: *Ishraq*.

very this-world, technological business too for Mīr Dāmād and his School of Isfahan peers, with medical, financial, political and military ramifications: the city as therapy as *Platonopolis*. (Engineering too was classed as both a mathematical and an occult science.⁹⁰) In this it explicitly riffs on the wildly popular pseudo-Aristotelian Arabic classic *Secret of Secrets* (*Sirr al-asrār*) – equally popular in its Latin translation as *Secretum secretorum* – wherein the First Teacher advises Alexander the Great at length that empire cannot be achieved but by means of occult science.⁹¹ And as Suhrawardī himself declared: the true philosopher combines occult means with manifest.⁹² Showcasing the same Solomonic-Pythagorean, lettrist-talismanic principle in action, his Safavid heir's *On Doffing* is thus an exceptionally useful model of early modern Shi'i occult rationalism. It is likewise a gem in that most classic of Western genres, *out-of-body philosophy*, the transmutation of physical endarkenment through metaphysical enlightenment, and deserves wider recognition and comparative study as such.

Nor is Mīr Dāmād's Illuminationism merely a late, passive, seventeenth-century repackaging of Neoplatonism since extincted by the march of colonial modernity; it is essential to making sense of that march and deconstructing its epistemological and ontological brutalities. As with "Renaissance" and "Scientific Revolution", that modern historiography awards the capitalised term "Enlightenment" solely to a relatively small cluster of seventeenth- and eighteenth-century West European thinkers is a classic colonialist tic. It is the most precise translation of *Ishrāq* too, given its early modern Muslim champions' consciously modernising project, their devotion to (occult) science as empirical philosophy, including revolutionary city design. According to the still-endemic Eurocentric and Protestant teleological myth, however, whereby only West Europeans can know the world, Renaissance births Scientific Revolution births Enlightenment births Modernity. A Renaissance man and Enlightened heir to the post-Mongol Occult-Scientific Revolution, Mīr Dāmād's example puts paid to that myth: for his contemporaries and near-contemporaries

90. M. Melvin-Koushki, "Powers of One", pp. 150, 167.

91. M. Melvin-Koushki, "How to Rule", p. 150; on its pre-Islamic Persian stemming see K. van Bladel, "The Iranian Characteristics and Forged Greek Attributions in the Arabic *Sirr al-asrār* (*Secret of Secrets*)", *Mélanges de l'Université Saint-Joseph* 57 (2004), pp. 151–172. Specifically, these occult sciences include astrology, alchemy, physiognomy and magic.

92. See the second *Talwihāt* quote above.

Bruno and Bacon, Kepler and Newton – archetypal Saints of Science, and occultists to a man – were passionately, emphatically committed to the same Pythagorean, Hermetic and Solomonic quest.⁹³

Modernity as disenchantment is equally a myth.⁹⁴ Thus Islamic Enlightenment helped drive the founding of the Islamic Republic as a modern nation-state, and continues to inform urban Iranian *mitāfīzīk* culture generally; its specific ethos persists in certain Twelver scholarly and seminary circles to the present. Most strikingly, ‘Allāma Ḥasan Ḥasanzāda Āmulī (b. 1929) explicitly compares one of his own visionary experiences, prompted in this case by ritual recitation of the declaration of divine Oneness (*tahlīl*), to Mīr Dāmād's out-of-body account.⁹⁵ That the same eminent ayatollah has also seen fit to author treatises on lettrism (and the equally Pythagorean science that is geomancy) should now come as no surprise.⁹⁶

As antidote to the modern historian's reflexive impulse to patronise premodern and modern Muslims as non-rational natives until proven otherwise, neatly excising “magic” from “philosophy”, I suggest we revisit Khomeini's understandably strident decolonising call to draw on a full century's worth of parapsychological data on the out-of-body experience as indispensable conceptual context. Not only are OBEs something that humans continue to frequently experience, intentionally or otherwise, and regardless of religious or cultural outlook; when conducted under controlled, artificially traumatic conditions the data they produce can sometimes be experimentally falsifiable too – the very definition of modern science. Conscious moderns, many Iranians today continue to use Mīr Dāmādian grimoires to achieve such “spirit flight” (*parvāz-i rūḥ*) as a rational-*cum*-noetic practice, though the state currently officially disavows it.⁹⁷

93. M. Melvin-Koushki, “Is (Islamic) Occult Science Science?” On the unprecedentedly democratising impulse of early modern Perso-Arabic grimoires, including ‘Alī Ṣafī's, see M. Melvin-Koushki, “How to Rule”; M. Melvin-Koushki, “Qizilbash Magic”.

94. J. Ā. Josephson-Storm, *The Myth of Disenchantment: Magic, Modernity, and the Birth of the Human Sciences* (Chicago, 2017).

95. *Hizār u yak kalīma*, 7 vols. (Qom, 1375–1391 Sh./1996–2012), 5, pp. 254–256.

96. M. Melvin-Koushki, “Pseudo-Shaykh Bahā'ī”, p. 257, 273.

97. A. Doostdar, *Iranian Metaphysicals*, pp. 34, 176–178, 189 and *passim*. Here Michel Foucault's (d. 1984) much-critiqued celebration of the Iranian Revolution as *political spirituality* – while not alive to such occult technologies and informed by Corbin's insistence on “true Islam” as mysticism – may be read as a form of poststructuralist, antiteleological gnosis: “He saw spirituality as a desire to liberate the body from the prison house of the soul” (B. Ghamari-Tabrizi, *Foucault in Iran: Islamic Revolution after the Enlightenment*

Words matter: they make and unmake worlds. In doffing his body, Mīr Dāmād did not think he was doing “mysticism” or “esotericism”, but rather Hermetic *gnōsis*, systematically employing tried-and-true mathematical-linguistic and visual-architectural mind-altering technologies to escape Plato’s Cave. But to theurgically ascend is to descend too, is to enact the Iamblichean injunction to *make the world* – in this case Safavid Isfahan – *theophanically beautiful and good and true*.⁹⁸ Celestial mind must be married to terrestrial body to make-the-One (*tawhīd*), that core, radically monistic Islamic article of philosophic theory and imperial practice – whence Mīr Dāmād’s argument for the supersession of the Hellenic dispensation (defined for him by Plotinian dualism) by the Islamic.⁹⁹ That his procedure was occult does not require it to be strictly nonrational; that its tenor was passionately Shi‘i and indebted to Sufism does not reduce it to mere Religion. To be sure, we now limit direct knowledge of the cosmos to (what we presume to be) mind-unaltered Science, and our cities are violently anti-therapeutic as a rule. Yet our own knowing of the nonvisible – the occult – is similarly technologically and mathematically driven, and still strains upward, traumatically, to the stars. Before leaping to scientific or religionistic judgment let us first take our Safavid worthy at his word. Western philosophy, like the human experience of the world, was and is often *weird*.

[Minneapolis, 2016], p. 63). A cognate inversion was preached by the Revolutionary sociologist-theologian ‘Alī Shari‘atī (d. 1977), who denounced contemporary clerical culture as sclerotically “Safavid” and called for a return to originary ‘Alid militancy (B. Ghamari-Tabrizi, *Foucault in Iran*, p. 25) – likewise unaware of the successful and fervently ‘Alid political-magical program of Mīr Dāmād and his *Safavid peers*.

98. W. J. Hanegraaff, *Hermetic Spirituality*, pp. 106–108, 224–225; G. Shaw, *Hellenic Tantra*.

99. M. Melvin-Koushki, “World as (Arabic) Text”, pp. 395–396. Crucially, the same radical monism defines the surviving Corpus Hermeticum; see W. J. Hanegraaff, *Hermetic Spirituality*, pp. 168, 186, 209–219.

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